



Water-Burial Among the Crocodiles

गोहि सभक बीच जलसमाधि

सम्पूर्ण त्रयी • The Complete Trilogy

A chapter-by-chapter teaching companion, in English

Gajendra Thakur • गजेन्द्र ठाकुर

About this teaching series

A chapter-by-chapter English study companion to Gajendra Thakur's Maithili epic — the complete trilogy (सम्पूर्ण त्रयी).

The scope. The complete series runs across three volumes and 301 numbered chapters — अध्याय -100 to 200 — followed by dramatic appendices. Vol-0 (-100...-1) is the pre-history; Vol-1 (0...100) and Vol-2 (101...200) carry the main narrative.

The spine. The village of Gaṛh Nārikel and its 1200-year witness, "Būṛhbā," hold the whole arc together. Its refrain — "the crocodile eats the body, not the name" — is the moral engine of every volume.

How each chapter is taught. One title card fixes the chapter's place, source and epigraph; then teaching cards vary in number with the chapter's length and density — longer, denser chapters receive more cards.

● *In many chapters you will meet*

RECURRING ELEMENTS

- An epigraph couplet in the voice of Gaṛh Nārikel
- A folk-song (लोकगीत) that states the theme
- A staged debate or nāṭya — प्रवेश, अंक, उपसंहार
- A closing kathā-dṛṣṭānta-uddharaṇa anthology
- A teaching takeaway that links to the larger arc



Conch and Silver

शंख आ रजत *Śaṅkha ā Rajat*

"Not all that glitters is silver, and not every name is a body — whoever takes the conch for silver takes the village for a map."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Dramatizes Vācaspati Miśra's Bhāmatī — the adhyāsa (superimposition) section on the four opening Brahma-sūtras

The frame: a village, a witness, and one small question

Conch and Silver • शंख आ रजत — card 1 of 3

Garh Nārikel. A village not on any large map, yet remembered for twelve hundred years in the root of a single pīpal tree at the heart of the Channā grove. Its perpetual witness is known only as "Būṛhbā."

The wager of the whole epic. Būṛhbā teaches one thing across every generation: the crocodile (goḥi) devours the body, never the name. To mistake glitter for truth is to mistake the name for the body — the same error that will run twelve centuries, from this debate-hall to today's screens.

The seed-question. Twelve hundred years ago, in a lamp-lit debate-hall, scholars gathered on a question small to look at but bottomless within: when a man mistakes a distant conch for silver, what exactly is that error?

● Composite voices, not portraits

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Sūtradhāra — stage-manager
- Vācaspati Miśra — commentator, host of the debate
- Ākṣepaka — the assembly's collective doubt
- Naiyāyika — defends anyathākhyāti
- Prābhākara — defends akhyāti

Three theories of error, tested at the door

Conch and Silver • शंख आ रजत — card 2 of 3

Naiyāyika — anyathākhyāti. The silver is real, sitting elsewhere (a shop, a memory), merely misplaced onto the conch. Vācaspati's reply: then a mere eye-defect would have to drag real silver across a city into your palm — no small flaw, but a miracle dressed as "illusion."

Prābhākara — akhyāti. Two correct cognitions arise — a bare "this" and a memory of silver — and the mind simply fails to mark them apart. Reply: a missed distinction is a kind of blindness, but it cannot explain the eager hand reaching for silver that isn't there.

Advaita — anirvacanīya. The silver was neither truly real (or the cognition would read "conch") nor simply unreal (no one reaches for a hare's horn). It was indeterminable — vivid, ungrounded, and vanishing the instant steady light corrects it.

● अनिर्वचनीय anirvacanīya

KEY TERM

- "That which cannot be pronounced either real or unreal."
- "Real" and "unreal" are contradictories, not two shades on one scale — affirming one is, in the same breath, denying the other.
- So error occupies the middle that logic seems to forbid.

From the conch to the world: the Bhāmatī move

Conch and Silver • शंख आ रजत — card 3 of 3

The extension. Vācaspati widens the mirage: the water a thirsty traveller runs toward is present, standing, ungraspable — like the silver. Now stretch it one step further.

The whole seen world. Body, senses, this hall, this lamp, this evening itself stand to the Self exactly as the silver stood to the conch — superimposed on a ground that does not itself change: the single, conscious ātman present alike in the child's body and the aged one.

The gentle correction. The entire Bhāmatī, the Sūtradhāra says, is nothing but the lamp being slowly, patiently trimmed — so that what we spent a lifetime calling silver we may see, without panic and without loss, was only ever a conch.

● Why this opens the epic

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The book's deepest question — what is error? — is asked first in its smallest dress.
- Names mistaken for bodies; maps mistaken for villages; glitter for truth.
- This single confusion is the root the whole novel will trace to its end.



Establishing the Self

आत्मसिद्धि-वाद *Ātmasiddhi-vāda*

"What says 'I' has its own breath for witness — the pond does not ask anyone how deep it is."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Dramatizes Udayana's *Ātmatattvaviveka* — a debate against Buddhist momentariness and idealism

The debate: is there anyone who says "I"?

Establishing the Self • आत्मसिद्धि-वाद — card 1 of 3

The question in four rooms. The debate asks one question four ways: who is asking? Is there someone who suffers, remembers, is bound — and can also be freed? Or is there only a river that mistakes its own waves for a bank?

The water-clock rule. Each side speaks in turn, measured by the ghaṭikā-yantra; neither may claim victory until the other has had its full time — a staged image of honest debate.

Movement one — momentariness. Kṣaṇabhadra argues everything real is momentary. Udayana answers: a stored seed waits through every season for rain, and the whole wait is the seed — so its "capacity" persists, which is the very permanence being denied.

● A composite opponent

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Udayanācārya — Mithilā's logician, defender of the Self
- Kṣaṇabhadra — one voice for many Buddhist logicians (Dharmakīrti, Ratnakīrti, Jñānaśrī)
- Śiṣya — the pupil who voices the assembly's doubt
- Pariṣad — the murmuring court

Against a world with no knower behind it

Establishing the Self • आत्मसिद्धि-वाद — card 2 of 3

The destruction argument. Kṣaṇabhadra says a thing perishes simply because it must. Udayana: then a stone in the sun is secretly ten-thousand stones, each perishing "by nature" with no hammer, weather or cause — a theory of change that leaves its most important change unexplained.

Movement two — idealism (vijñānavāda). If dream-gardens feel outer with no outer object, why assume any outer world? Reply: you yourself keep dream and waking apart — and that very sorting is done from a standpoint outside both, reporting something a dream cannot give and the world can.

The debate refutes itself. And to argue at all, your mind must receive a cause from outside it — my voice, entering your ear, addressed to a hearer you treat as distinct. If nothing is outside cognition, whom are you speaking to?

● The knower behind knowing

KEY MOVE

- "I know" is like "I cut": cutting is an act, and every act needs an agent that begins before it and remains after.
- The axe is blunted by cutting; the cutter is not destroyed by it.
- So the knower persists through the act of knowing.

Memory proves a Self — and a Self worth keeping

Establishing the Self • आत्मसिद्धि-वाद — card 3 of 3

The mango, thirty years on. I now remember a mango tasted in childhood. Tasting was one event, long perished; remembering is another, in a body wholly changed. For this to be my memory — not a stranger's diary — one thing must have been present at both moments.

The crowd that remembers nothing. A crowd, once scattered, remembers nothing; no crowd is left to remember. Yet I remember. Momentary flashes, each perishing before the next, could no more bridge this than one wave could recall a wave that broke an hour before its birth.

Movement four — bondage and freedom. If there is no Self, no one is bound and no one freed, and every teacher taught an empty room to let go. But a Self that mistook itself for the body, and suffered that error, is the same Self that can unlearn it — freed not by vanishing, but by lasting, at last, without the old illusion.

● Why the Self matters here

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Only a persisting subject makes memory, ownership and liberation more than words.
- Udayana turns even the opponent's "hidden continuity" into the ātman under another name.
- The pre-history plants the Self that the whole novel will test against water and forgetting.



Who Made This World?

केऽ बनौलक ई जगत? *Ke'i Banaulak Ī Jagat?*

"The tree asked, 'Who planted me?' The earth laughed: 'The one who plants never asks.'"

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A 30-minute village play based on Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali — the inference of a world-maker

A quarrel in the village square

Who Made This World? • केऽ बनौलक ई जगत? — card 1 of 3

The setting. The Sūtradhāra brings not a tale of kings and demons but the oldest quarrel of all: who made the rising sun, the falling rain, the ripening rice — someone, or did it simply happen?

The players. The Ācārya (an Udayana-figure) meets Cārvāka, the quick village skeptic, with a potter-woman, the boy Modhu, old Būṛh Kākā, and Lekhnī Dīdī who copies the sacred leaves. The whole proof is staged in things a village already knows.

First flower — kāryāt. "Who made this pot?" "The potter, this morning." "But you never saw her make it." "Because pots don't shape themselves!" The Ācārya asks only that the vast, ordered world be looked at with the same honest eye.

● *Nyāyakusumāñjali, staged*

THE ARGUMENT'S FOUR FLOWERS

- कार्यात् — a made thing needs a maker (the pot)
- आयोजनात् / धृत्यादेः — order + upkeep (the granary wall)
- पदात् — words have fixed, assigned meanings (naming)
- प्रत्ययतः — testimony of the unseen needs a knower of it

Order, upkeep, and the first name

Who Made This World? • केऽ बनौलक ई जगत? — card 2 of 3

The granary wall — order and maintenance. Bricks do not choose their own order, nor do the rain-clouds choose to come in Sāvan and not in Māgh. Someone set the order at the start; someone keeps it standing against wind and rain — as a wall, once built, still needs a hand to hold it up.

The naming of "tinkolī" — padāt. Children squabble over what to call a strange new fruit; Būṛh Kākā ends it by decree: "Call it tinkolī." Cārvāka notes the word did not choose its own meaning — an elder tied it. So who tied the very first word to the very first meaning?

The reliable witness — pratyayataḥ. You trust your mother about fire because she saw it and had no reason to deceive you. Verses about the unseen fruit of deeds can only be trusted if someone directly knew the unseen — a knower the Ācārya will call God.

● An unbroken chain of names

KEY MOVE

- A rope of names passed down needs a first knot.
- Repetition never turns a guess into knowledge, however old.
- So the chain points back to a first, reliable knower.

The verdict: not silence, but a better question

Who Made This World? • केऽ बनौलक ई जगत? — card 3 of 3

Chance is not an answer. Cārvāka pleads chance. The Ācārya: chance must still work on something — atoms that combine, and combine in just the order that yields pots, rivers, rice, children. Left truly alone, chance does not even know to try again.

Cārvāka leaves — still doubting, now asking better. He cannot answer tonight, and says so honestly. He leaves as sure as ever that a pot needs a potter and a good question deserves a patient answer, not a loud one — and now he asks better questions.

The old texts' true ending. The play closes as the old books do — not by silencing the doubter, but by wishing the fragrance of this flower of reason to believer and skeptic alike, so both go home a little wiser. If one child asked "but why?" once more than usual, the little pot found its shape tonight.

● The temper of Nyāya

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Reason asks only for honest looking — not blind faith, not surrender.
- The doubter is honoured, not crushed.
- Even a children's play carries the full Naiyāyika proof of īśvara.



The Wishing-Jewel of Thought

चिन्तामणि रत्न *Cintāmaṇi Ratna*

"Mind steady, a clod is a diamond; mind shaken, a diamond is a clod — the jewel is not outside, but in the eye that knows it."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Dramatizes Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi — and, above all, its method

The method before the doctrine

The Wishing-Jewel of Thought • चिंतामणि रत्न — card 1 of 3

Testing the mortar first. Like a mason who tests his mortar before trusting a wall, Gaṅgeśa will let no conclusion bear weight until he has defined valid knowledge and pervasion so precisely that the definition survives every blow — including his own.

The signature technique. State the weakest, most exact form of a claim; invite the sharpest available blow; and if it lands, thank the opponent and rebuild. Self-refutation and refinement — not louder assertion — is how the jewel is cut.

First movement — maṅgalācaraṇa. Does the auspicious invocation cause anything? Gaṅgeśa concedes the objection's full force, then shows the invocation removes obstacles rather than directly producing completion — a rule bound by a condition, exactly like smoke and fire.

● Composite voices

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — the logician who refines his own claim first
- Bauddha — the sharp opponent, doubting unseen causes and unseen agents
- Mīmāṃsaka — a ritual scholar
- Śiṣya — whose plain questions keep the debate earthed

Two definitions, cut and re-cut

The Wishing-Jewel of Thought • चिंतामणि रत्न — card 2 of 3

Valid knowledge (prāmāṇya). First try: a cognition is valid when it presents a quality just where it truly is. The conch-silver case seems to split it — one cognition, valid in its "this," invalid in its "silver." Gaṅgeśa's answer: a mixed cognition is two claims on one glance, each testable apart, so no contradiction remains.

Pervasion (vyāpti). The bond between sign (smoke) and proven (fire) is refined four times, each patch closing a door the last left open — until "co-location where the sign never stands where the proven is wholly absent" survives the Buddhist's every counter-example.

Why a lifetime. "I am beginning to see why this text took a lifetime to write." Because every sentence already sits before an opponent as sharp as tonight's — and that is the only kind of sentence worth building anything on.

● *The mason's patch*

METHOD IN ONE IMAGE

- A wall tested four times by its mason, and still standing,
- is worth more than a wall no one has yet thought to push.
- Be dazzled by the method, not by the count of patches.

The inference of God — named with precision

The Wishing-Jewel of Thought · चिंतामणि रत्न — card 3 of 3

Naming the subject. Not vaguely "earth and the elements," but: "whatever is an effect and is not already known to us to be made by an embodied human maker." This excludes the pot, and excludes nothing genuinely in dispute.

Defining "agency" (kartṛtva). Not the mere presence of knowledge, desire and effort — we have those toward countless things we never made — but being the effective cause, as the potter stands to this pot, not as a bystander stands to a fire he did not light.

Why the chain must stop. An embodied agent presupposes a body, itself an effect needing just such a maker. The chain cannot end in an embodied maker without regress; it stops at a knower–willer–agent whose effort depends on no prior body. That, and nothing grander, is what we call God.

● Navya-Nyāya, dramatized

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Precision of the subject-term is half the proof.
- Progress, not defeat, is the mark of a well-run debate.
- The wishing-jewel is the disciplined eye itself.



Guarding the Memory

स्मृति-रक्षा *Smṛti-rakṣā*

"The body dissolves in clay; the name holds on the leaf — what the village keeps in mind, no hand can erase."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An original play in the debate-hall lineage of -100/-99/-98 — where logic meets a death by the well

A death by the well, and a rushed verdict

Guarding the Memory • स्मृति-रक्षा — card 1 of 2

The turn. Earlier illusions were a convenience — no one died; a hand merely came away empty. Here the hand is not empty: the well is full. Hulāsā, the young copyist, is found drowned, and the word "suicide" stands up before the cause of death is even known.

Prestige versus truth. Kṣaṇapūra the ritualist and the village head want the case closed quickly, to protect the debate-hall's name. Vācaspati refuses: absence of witnesses proves absence, not agency — as no smoke in a dark room proves no fire ever burned.

The means, not the speaker. Testimony's validity rests on its instrument, not the speaker's caste or sex. Hulāsā's unsent last words, written alone for no listener, are free of deceit — for deceit always needs an audience.

● The debate-hall, ageing

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Vācaspati Mīśra — the aged ācārya, voice still firm
- Budhuā — his lifelong servant at the lamp and conch
- Hulāsā — the copyist found drowned
- Kṣaṇapūra — ritualist, guardian of "prestige"
- Ratneśa — the village head

The unfinished line, and the birth of Būṛhbā

Guarding the Memory • स्मृति-रक्षा — card 2 of 2

"हम..." — left unfinished. The last leaf breaks off mid-word: "I..." Vācaspati will not complete it. To finish it by guess would be his imagination's victory, not the guarding of her memory. To guard a memory is to keep its incompleteness intact, not falsely closed.

The verdict in stone. "Cause unknown, name Hulāsā, justice pending." To admit "cause unknown" is not shame but the mark of good learning — the same rigour once turned on the conch is now owed to a powerless girl.

The vow that outlives a life. Budhuā vows to keep watch by the conch and rope for as long as any name is erased by injustice. Such a vow outlasts one life — and across twelve hundred years "the old servant" becomes "Būṛhbā," the witness who opened this whole epic.

● Where trilogy meets novel

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The tools of proof are worthless if they cannot guard one weak name.
- Logic reveals truth; guarding revealed truth is a separate act.
- Budhuā's vow is the thread the reader will find again in the Channā grove.



The Submerged Manuscript

जलमग्न पाण्डुलिपि *Jalamagna Pāṇḍulipi*

"A flood can drown a book, not the throat — words written on the heart are not wetted by water."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An original play in Udayana's monastery — set against the tradition that his Kiraṇāvalī opens with no invocation

The fire, and a life spent to save the books

The Submerged Manuscript • जलमग्न पाण्डुलिपि — card 1 of 2

"My invocation." Pupil Someśvara asks why the Kiraṇāvalī carries no maṅgalācaraṇa. Udayana: "Care, study, clear writing, timely revision — that is my invocation. A work completed without obstacle is its own proof of auspiciousness."

The fire. A lamp topples; the manuscript-hall catches. The oldest copies and the Kiraṇāvalī autograph are still inside. Jīvantī — Budhuā's pupil, the manuscript-guardian — proposes to sink the bundles in the pond, beyond the fire's reach.

The drowning. She swims deep to keep the bundles dry, her hair snags on a root, and she will not let go: "I was taught to be a witness — a witness to the books too." Aged Budhuā reaches her too late; the bundle is saved, Jīvantī is not.

● The monastery, by night

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Udayanācārya — philosopher-host, author of the Kiraṇāvalī
- Budhuā — Vācaspati's old servant, now here, vow-bound
- Jīvantī — manuscript-guardian, Budhuā's pupil
- Someśvara — the pupil who asks about the invocation
- Śambhunāth — the abbot, guardian of prestige

The price of an obstacle-free completion

The Submerged Manuscript · जलमग्न पाण्डुलिपि — card 2 of 2

The abbot's scale. By morning Śambhunāth is relieved "the manuscript survived." Udayana rebukes him: "You weighed the book before the girl — your scale tips toward the text."

His own words, turned back. Someśvara presses: "You said a work completed without obstacle is its own proof — but was this completed without obstacle? A life was lost in it." Udayana concedes the words were not false, only incomplete: he forgot that the price at which that completion was bought is itself a matter of proof.

A name at the library door. He makes a rule — this monastery will name the guardian wherever it preserves a text. Jīvantī's name is carved where the catalogue is written, and a "memory-chamber" (स्मृति-कक्ष) is founded: the list of scriptures and the list of names will run together.

● One line, two monasteries

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- "Logic reveals truth; guarding revealed truth is a separate act" — Vācaspati's line, now heard from a second mouth.
- The vow now holds two names: Hulāsā, Jīvantī.
- Budhuā's whispered "हम् ..." — the unfinished word he still carries.



The Silence of Four Mouths

चारि मुखक मौन *Cāri Mukhak Maun*

"All four mouths spoke, yet one thing stayed hidden — behind every answer stands a silence."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An original play — four schools debate under the pīpal while a famine crowd waits at the gate

Four philosophies, one hungry crowd

The Silence of Four Mouths • चारिमुखक मौन — card 1 of 2

The changed topic. In a famine year, Udayana halts the scheduled debate and asks the four scholars one plain question: "What does your philosophy say about the starving crowd at the gate?" Each retreats inside its own system.

The four answers. Sāṅkhya: suffering is of the three guṇas, cured by knowledge, not grain. Cārvāka's Rudradatta breaks the pattern — "if the store has grain and the belly is empty, give it; that is plain sense." Mīmāṃsaka: no Vedic injunction, so alms is optional. The Buddhist monk tangles in the emptiness of giver, gift and receiver.

Sohan collapses. A starving villager, Sohan, staggers in and dies by the pīpal root before the debate ends. Four systems, each complete, and not one could say in time: "food first, debate after."

● *Four schools, and the famine*

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Viśvambhar — Sāṅkhya: the three guṇas
- Rudradatta — Cārvāka poet: perception first
- Śīlabhadra — Buddhist monk: compassion, and emptiness
- Harinātha — Mīmāṃsaka: dharma is Vedic injunction
- Sohan — the starving villager who dies

The witness-tree, and the four faces

The Silence of Four Mouths · चारिमुखक मौन — card 2 of 2

Budhuā's rebuke. "Viśvambhar spoke of the guṇas, Rudradatta of perception, Śīlabhadra of emptiness, Harinātha of injunction. Sohan sat among these four tales, listening, and died. Was there not one tale that could have said at once — food first, then debate?"

Not philosophy's defeat. Udayana: your four knowledges are not false; but sitting together you could not speak with one voice for one life. This is not the defeat of philosophy — it is the defeat of those of us who love philosophy more than life.

Hands on the bark. Budhuā asks the pīpal to hold the four voices as witness; the scholars each lay a hand on it. Henceforth whoever debates in its shade must first ask, "Is anyone hungry at the gate?" The tree becomes the sākṣī-vṛkṣa, later "Pīpar Brahmā" — four faces, four philosophies.

● Knowledge before compassion

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The vow now holds three names: Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sohan.
- Far ahead, in the Channā grove, the pīpal will give four answers — all four false.
- Because truth does not live where knowledge insists on speaking before compassion.



The Conch's Last Question

शंखक अन्तिम प्रश्न *Śaṅkhak Antim Praśna*

"What you once recognised, the dawn asks of you again — but one whose answer is steady does not fear the question."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An original play returning the conch-silver error of -100 to Udayana's monastery, at the end of a doubter's life

A lifetime of doubt, come to die

The Conch's Last Question • शंखक अन्तिम प्रश्न — card 1 of 2

The doubter returns. The Ākṣepaka — the voice first heard in -100, who spent sixty years touring debate-halls raising doubts — comes back, dying, to Udayana's monastery with one last question, asked for himself, not for debate.

The question. If all of life is a conch-mistaken-for-silver, what is death? The end of the illusion — or an illusion that could never itself be tested? And if the very knower of the illusion was false, was sixty years of doubt worth anything at all?

Disagreement is not absence. Udayana notes the three schools (anyathākhyāti, akhyāti, anirvacanīya) all agree that error is error; they differ only on its mechanism. Their disagreement marks the subtlety of the subject, not the absence of truth. But the doubter's question is about death, not mechanism.

● End of a life

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Udayanācārya — now in his final year
- The Ākṣepaka — the doubter of -100, sixty years on
- Budhuā — vow-bound witness, who answers in the end
- Keśava — the young pupil in attendance

Budhuā's answer, and the silver light

The Conch's Last Question • शंखक अन्तिम प्रश्न — card 2 of 2

The value of doubt. Budhuā answers, not Udayana: three names — Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sohan — each a victim of illusion, and each time the instruments of proof came late. But one thing never came late: the decision to be a witness. That decision arrives after proof falls silent.

The conch, not the silver. "Knowledge can only name the illusion; stepping out of it is the work of will, memory, love. You spent sixty years avoiding taking the conch for silver. I spent sixty years learning how much the conch is worth even without being silver — for it is still a conch, in my hand, and keeping it is my work."

Neither conch nor silver. Death is not the end of illusion, but the moment the conch shows its true worth without trying to be silver. The doubter dies at peace; a faint silver light — neither conch nor silver — rises from his eyes toward the sākṣī-vṛkṣa. Villagers will call it "Rākas."

● The circle of the conch

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The vow now holds four names.
- The conch of -100 completes its circle — but completion is only the door to a new question.
- Foreshadow: the Channā-grove kabaddī, where the Rākas throw silver light.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -92

The Prisoner of the Water-Clock

जल-घड़ीक कैदी *Jal-gharīk Kaidī*

"Drop by drop the water falls, drop by drop the time — the prisoner of the clock never learns the end of his sentence."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The first full portrait of Gaṛh Nārikel village — the future stage of the whole novel

The village, and a farmer who cannot be heard

The Prisoner of the Water-Clock • जल-घड़ीक कैदी — card 1 of 2

Nārikel-ghāṭ. The first detailed portrait of the village that will host the whole novel — the twin pond, the pīpal "witness-tree," the Kamalā-Balān river. Ācārya Keśava (Udayana's pupil) runs a court and loves procedure: every dispute is timed by a ghaṭikā-yantra, a pierced brass bowl that sinks when a speaker's time is up.

The blocked channel. Sukhdev Mahto, an honest poor farmer, comes daily for weeks: the powerful Ugrasen Ṭhākur has dammed the channel that waters his field. But his plain, unlettered complaint always sits behind grander disputes, and the water-clock always runs out — "come tomorrow."

Time as a barrier. Ugrasen's learned lawyer raises a new technical question each day, each demanding a fresh water-clock. Six weeks pass; drought comes; the daughter's buffalo Kajarī starves; Sukhdev himself withers like his own rice.

● A village dispute

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Ācārya Keśava — Udayana's pupil, lover of procedure
- Sukhdev Mahto — honest farmer, denied water
- Ugrasen Ṭhākur — the powerful landholder
- Budhuā — the aged witness at the pīpal root

The unfinished sentence, and "Loth"

The Prisoner of the Water-Clock · जल-घड़ीक कैदी — card 2 of 2

"My daughter..." At last Sukhdev rises to speak — "Ācārya, my daughter..." — and collapses dead by the pīpal root, the sentence unfinished. Keśava rushes: "I would have heard you today!" — but the words are now seed sown after the field has dried.

Budhuā's diagnosis. "Your order was not wrong. It only forgot that for many people time itself is a luxury — and one who cannot afford it reaches the end of his body, not the end of the queue." Keśava adds a rule: whoever waits more than three days is heard first — the "Sukhdev-niyama," never carved (his land passed to Ugrasen's steward; his daughter's name never entered the record).

The half-open mouth. A ghost lingers by the pīpal — "Loth," still as the dead but mouth half-open like the living, the sentence never finished. Budhuā tells the fearful: he needs only that his words be heard one day. Nārikel-ghāṭ becomes "Gaṛh Nārikel"; only the names of the village's hunger change — date, file, court verandah.

● A tool that turns on the weak

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The ghaṭikā-yantra, built to discipline scholars' debate,
- becomes a new barrier against the powerless when time is shared unequally.
- An unfinished sentence cannot be completed by any witness — Budhuā's oldest rule.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -91

The Light of the Cobblers' Quarter

चर्मकार टोलाक उजास *Carmakār Tolāk Ujās*

"The hand that stitches hide has its name on the leaf too — the quarter's lamp and the palace's lamp burn the same oil."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Young Gaṅgeśa among the leather-workers — the part of his life hidden behind the shine of scripture

A truth of Nyāya, learned from a drum

The Light of the Cobblers' Quarter • चर्मकार टोलाक उजास — card 1 of 2

The quarter at the edge. Past the dried Maral-Gaṅg lies the Camār quarter — drying hides, making drums, stitching shoes: work the village needs but keeps from its threshold. Here live Somar the finest drum-maker, Ratnā the midwife whose herbal and birthing knowledge is written nowhere, and their bright daughter Mālatī.

The fevered stranger. Young Gaṅgeśa collapses at their door, feverish, clutching palm-leaves, muttering "without proof, no prameya...". Ratnā takes him in — across the "impurity" taboo of a Brahmin in a Camār home — and nurses him fifteen days.

Mālatī's drum. She asks: if a speaker's mind holds no falsehood, how can the word be untrue, whoever the speaker? Her proof is her father's drums — if the hide is wrongly stretched the drum speaks falsely, however skilled the player; stretched right, it speaks as true as any palace instrument. Gaṅgeśa: "You have brought reliability (āptatā) onto the purity of the instrument, not the speaker's caste. You spoke the science of Nyāya."

● The Camār quarter

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Gaṅgeśa — the future author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi
- Mālatī — Somar's daughter, sharp and unlettered
- Ratnā — midwife; keeper of unwritten knowledge
- Somar — the finest drum-maker in the village
- Budhuā — who foresees the forgetting

The foundation the world forgets

The Light of the Cobblers' Quarter • चर्मकार टोलाक उजास — card 2 of 2

Marriage, and uproar. Gaṅgeśa keeps returning; within two years marriage is arranged. The Brahmin quarter erupts with threats that his work will never be taught. By the pīpal, Budhuā tells him: this marriage is not your fall but your text's foundation — yet the world will read your text and forget Mālatī's drum, making your marriage a tale of pity, not of justice.

The legend that covers a debt. The Tattvacintāmaṇi — twelve-thousand-texts' worth of thought — is taught everywhere; but the world forgets the drum and later invents Gaṅgeśa's genius as a tantric boon or Kālī's grace: easier to fabricate a divine tale than to admit a cobbler-woman's daughter saw a deep truth of epistemology in drum-hide.

Goddess or witch. The women's evening circle by the Maral-Gaṅg — where unwritten knowledge passes hand to hand — is feared and later called "ḍāin" (witch). Knowledge that is not written down, the village calls either goddess or witch; it has no name in between. So the women learn: a quiet voice is a safe voice.

● Whose light is recorded

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Budhuā's vow now guards Ratnā's and Mālatī's names — if not on scripture's page, then on another.
- An alternative to -97's divine-boon legend: a human teacher, unrecorded.
- The counter-canon the whole Videha project sets out to recover.



Budhuā's Water-Burial

बुधुआक जलसमाधि *Budhuāk Jalasamādhī*

"The crocodile took the body, released the name — one who takes water-burial dwells not at the pond's bottom, but in the village's mind."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The keystone of the pre-history — the birth of the "Būṛhbā" ghost and the novel's title-image

The last witness, and a memory too heavy to carry

Budhuā's Water-Burial · बुधुआक जलसमाधि — card 1 of 3

Still alive. Generations on, Ācārya Vardhamāna (seventh in Keśava's line) writes on the Tattvacintāmaṇi — and Budhuā still lives, as ordinary to the village as the pīpal or the pond. Children call him "Būṛhbā"; he can no longer walk, and to everyone who passes he speaks a name — Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā — as if keeping them from falling out of the air.

Centuries inside one man. Asked his age, he answers: "When I began there was only the coconut-row, the pond and pīpal, and an ācārya arguing that a conch was mistaken for silver." "Vācaspati Miśra — but that was centuries ago!" "Yes. Those centuries now sit inside me, in my memory — and memory becomes a burden when the body carrying it grows weak."

The fear. If he dies as an ordinary man, where will the names go — Hulāsā's, Jīvantī's, Sukhdev's unfinished sentence, Ratnā's drum — none carved in stone, none in any book, held only in one old man's memory, ending with him like a lamp's light?

● Vol-0, gathered into one man

THE NAMES HE CARRIES

- Hulāsā — the copyist (-96)
- Jīvantī — the manuscript-guardian (-95)
- Sohan — the famine's death (-94)
- Sukhdev — the prisoner of the water-clock (-92)
- Ratnā & Mālatī — the drum's unrecorded truth (-91)

The water-burial

Budhuā's Water-Burial · बुधुआक जलसमाधि — card 2 of 3

Moonlight like silver. That night he carries his conch and rope to the pond, moonlight spread like silver on the water — the very conch-silver image of –100. He speaks a last word to each name: Hulāsā (carrying her unfinished "हम..." not to complete but to preserve), Jīvantī ("I finish your sentence not with your word but with my act — I will be a witness, always"), Sukhdev (bearing the "Sukhdev-niyama"), Ratnā (writing her name in the water, in memory, not ink).

"The vow breaks the limit of a lifespan." To Vācaspati, at the last: "You said a vow outlasts one life. Today I understand — it does not merely outlast a life; it breaks the limit of a lifespan itself." He sits down into the water as into sleep, without struggle or fear; the pond flashes silver for one instant, then stills.

Only a conch and a rope. At dawn the fishermen find only the conch and worn rope, neatly placed — no body, no footprints, no struggle — and the pīpal greener, as if its roots gained something overnight. Vardhamāna places the conch in the root: "Budhuā did not die. He has only become nearer to this tree, this water, and every memory of this village than any living man could ever be."

● जलसमाधि · water-burial

THE TITLE-IMAGE

- The crocodile (gohi) takes the body, releases the name.
- Water-burial is not descent to the pond's bed — it is entry into the village's memory.
- This is the seed of the whole novel's title and its moral engine.

The birth of Būṛhbā, and "twelve hundred years"

Budhuā's Water-Burial · बुधुआक जलसमाधि — card 3 of 3

A presence at dusk. From then, a patient old presence lingers by the pīpal at dusk, whispering names; children hear the old stories though no one knows who tells them. "Būṛhbā," the village says, "is still sitting there."

Folk time, not the calendar. Details blur; the age becomes a round, memorable number — "twelve hundred years" — neither wholly true nor false, like the conch that is never quite silver yet keeps silver's memory in its shine. (By Vol-0's own clock the gap from Vācaspati is nearer four or five centuries; the number is a folk idiom for "rememberable antiquity," true to the story's inner time, not the outer calendar.)

The thread into the novel. The roots reach toward the Channā grove — or perhaps the grove is only the old pīpal's reach; the village never settles the question. Whoever sits there at dusk still meets a patient old presence, holding the names, waiting — as it once sat by Vācaspati's door, tending the lamp. This is the Būṛhbā the reader will meet, "twelve hundred years on one branch," in the Channā-grove kabaddī of Vol-1.

● Where Vol-0 becomes the novel

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Būṛhbā is Vol-0's memory made permanent — the reader's guide through Vol-1 and Vol-2.
- Symbolic, non-linear time: 1885, 1934, 1977 and now will be leapt in one kabaddī turn.
- The crocodile eats the body, not the name — now proven in a life.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -89

First Night, First Flood

पहिल राति, पहिल बाढि *Pahil Rāti, Pahil Bāṛhi*

"The first flood took the house, not the village — the night that survived became the seed of the dawn."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- One year after the water-burial — Būṛhbā's first test, and the origin of the name "Gaṛh Nārikel"

A witness who cannot save is only a spectator

First Night, First Flood · पहिल राति, पहिल बाढि — card 1 of 2

The cloudburst. A year after his water-burial, a midnight storm bursts the weak earthen embankment where the Camār quarter sits. Būṛhbā, now one with the water, feels the flood coming and screams — but his hands slip through doors without sound. "A witness who cannot save is only a spectator, not a witness."

The dream that wakes the quarter. Seven-year-old Gaurī — Ratnā and Mālatī's fourth-generation heir, carrying a faint "half-ghost" thread — hears Būṛhbā in a dream repeating "Rise. Rise." She wakes screaming; her grandmother opens the door to the roar of water, and the quarter runs for high ground.

The current turned, for one instant. The embankment collapses toward the Camār quarter. Būṛhbā bends the current for a single moment, and Gaurī's family reaches the old cremation-mound — shunned as inauspicious, and therefore empty and safe. Seven die that night, including her great-grandmother Subhāgī, whose last words were "Did Gaurī survive?" The six Camār dead go unrecorded.

● The night of the flood

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Būṛhbā — the water-witness, tested for the first time
- Gaurī — the child who hears him; Ratnā's heir
- Subhāgī — the great-grandmother lost to the flood
- The Camār quarter — at the embankment's weakest point

"A witness becomes half-ghost"

First Night, First Flood · पहिल राति, पहिल बाढि — card 2 of 2

The weeping tree. At dawn Būṛhbā weeps for the first time since the water-burial — no tears, no sound, yet every pīpal leaf is wetter than dew, as if the tree itself wept. To Gaurī: "I couldn't save you all, only some; but saving what can be saved is no small thing."

The half-ghost. "You heard my voice when no one else could. Perhaps one who is ready to be a witness becomes half-ghost — neither wholly living nor dead, a thin thread between two worlds." The saying spreads: a child's strange dream, or a groundless dread before calamity, may mean Būṛhbā is speaking to a half-ghost.

The rampart, and the name. The village rebuilds the embankment in brick and stone — the Camār side first and strongest, for the first time valuing the quarter's safety equally. "Nārikel-ghāṭ" becomes "Gaṛh Nārikel" — gaṛh, "fort," in memory of that rampart, bought with seven lives.

● Memory tied to a place-name

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Mithilā's flood country: embankment resources mirror social hierarchy.
- A fictional etymology binds the place-name to memory and justice.
- Būṛhbā's first lesson: not all can be saved — but saving some is no small act.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -88

The Witch's Accusation

डाइनक आरोप *Dāink Ārop*

"Whom the village called 'witch,' no one asked her name — an accusation burns the body; truth stays on the leaf."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Twenty years on — how a "witch" charge is manufactured to seize a prospering quarter's land

An accusation built to order

The Witch's Accusation • डाइनक आरोप — card 1 of 2

The prospering quarter. Twenty years after the flood, the Camār quarter is safe and prosperous — its drums sell across Mithilā — and the old landed families resent it. Gaurī, now 27, is its healer-midwife, Ratnā's fourth-generation heir, still half-ghost, still hearing Būṛhbā before calamities.

The plot. Pratāpsen Ṭhākur (Ugrasen's grandson), his wealth shrinking, plots with Paṇḍit Yaśpati: declare a quarter "impure" and its land rights can be "reviewed" for purification. Yaśpati's target is Gaurī — she knows herbs, walks out alone at night, speaks to the unseen at the pīpal. "Proof is manufactured, not asked for. Fear runs faster than reason."

The twist. Pratāpsen's own son falls dangerously feverish. He forbids a "Camār woman" to touch the boy, but his wife Kamalā Devī secretly summons Gaurī, who breaks the fever by dawn. Yaśpati inverts it: "The fever rose, then she came, then it broke — proof she caused it first, then feigned a cure. That is the witch's ploy."

● The conspiracy

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Gaurī — healer-midwife, branded a "ḍāin"
- Pratāpsen Ṭhākur — the resentful landholder
- Yaśpati — the ritualist who manufactures the charge
- Kamalā Devī — Pratāpsen's wife, whom Gaurī saves
- Phulesarī — leader of the women's secret circle

The charge, and the torches

The Witch's Accusation • डाइनक आरोप — card 2 of 2

Pride, not gratitude. Pratāpsen — his pride more wounded than his gratitude that his son lives — seizes the argument. An emergency assembly is called; Yaśpati declares Gaurī a witch using tantra on children, orders her barred from religious functions and her quarter's land moved from the embankment, "for purification."

The silence of the saved. Many whose children Gaurī saved sit stunned — torn between fear and gratitude. A few voices object, but Yaśpati's authority and Pratāpsen's power crush them. Torches begin to move toward the quarter.

The names return. Gaurī suddenly remembers Ratnā, Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev — all the names Būṛhbā has carried, all whose truth stood incomplete before the great systems. She runs to the pīpal: "And if this time Būṛhbā can do nothing?"

● *Superstition made to order*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Ḍāin-charges historically tracked land disputes, enmity, and women's independence.
- Widows, the childless, or independent healers were the usual targets.
- Superstition is often consciously engineered by power and property — not spontaneous.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -87

At the Quarter's Gate

टोलाक द्वारपर *Tolāk Dvārpar*

"A torch can reach the gate, but the name won't burn inside — a quarter awake keeps its wall higher than the fire."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Directly after -88 — the torch-mob at the gate, and the women who decide to stop being silent

A living wall, and a snuffed torch

At the Quarter's Gate • टोलाक द्वारपर — card 1 of 1

"Don't come late for me." Gaurī at the pīpal: "You came late for Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev — don't come late for me tonight." Būṛhbā cannot touch a body or quench a torch, and will not lie: "But the truth in this quarter tonight is stronger than me or you. It needs only a place to come out — many mouths, long silent."

The women at the gate. The torch-mob arrives; but Phulesarī comes first, then ten, then twenty women — a living wall holding lamps and children between the mob and the quarter. Then Kamalā Devī, Pratāpsen's own wife, runs barefoot from the haveli: "Your son, whom you watched dying, lives today by the hand you would burn." "This is men's business!" "No — this is truth's business, and truth does not listen only to men's ears."

The testimony, and the light. One by one, women of every caste step out — breech births, snakebite, deathbed vigils given free — each testimony pulling a brick from Yaśpati's mountain of lies. As he makes his last stand, his torch snuffs itself out — no wind, no water — as if blown from within. Yaśpati is displaced, not punished; in his eyes Gaurī reads a colder patience, a new plot already taking shape.

● Collective witness

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A folk form of Vācaspati's śabda-pramāṇa (–96): speaker's intent, hearer's trust, the truth of the moment.
- A lone woman's word can be doubted; many consistent testimonies break the doubt — modern law agrees.
- No illusion of complete justice: injustice does not end in one night or one victory.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -86

The Crocodile of Time

समयक गोहि *Samayak Gohi*

"Time too is a crocodile — it swallows generation on generation — but the name the village keeps, even time cannot swallow."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Būṛhbā's sight breaks its own bounds — the structural key to the whole ten-volume design

Three visions across time

The Crocodile of Time • समयक गोहि — card 1 of 2

Būṛhbā unmoored. After Yaśpati leaves for the Darbhanga court, Būṛhbā flickers between water and shadow, "in many places at once," his voice arriving broken, "filtered through many voices." He is seeing what his known world cannot contain.

1885, a dried field, a night grove. First: a port in 1885 — migrants pressing thumbprints on papers they cannot read, black water waiting below like a crocodile. Second: a rally crushed by lathis, an old land-deed trampled in the dust — "not Sukhdev's, another Sukhdev, the same story rewritten." Third: the Channā grove at night, a kabaddī played by the non-living, an ancient figure on a branch with a worn conch, feet an inch off the ground.

"That figure is me." "That figure on the branch — it is me! But I am here, before you. How am I in two places at once?" Around it stand a handless woman, a wet-haired figure, a four-faced figure, a half-open-mouthed figure, and small creatures throwing silver light — the dead of Vol-0, gathered.

● Vol-0's dead, seen ahead

THE FIGURES IN THE GROVE

- The ancient referee with the conch — Būṛhbā himself
- A handless woman · a wet-haired figure
- A four-faced figure · a half-open-mouthed figure
- Small creatures throwing silver light ("Rākas")
- Living children, watching, breath held

Time is a crocodile, not a river

The Crocodile of Time • समयक गोहि — card 2 of 2

The revelation. "I thought time a river I watch flow. Now I think time is a crocodile — it lives in the river but ignores its current, going back, forward, in two places at once. It eats the body, the era, the year — but it cannot eat the name. A name slips even from the crocodile's mouth and lives again on another shore."

The children are ours. The grove's children are future children who received the names — Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā, Mālatī — by some unknown road. "Perhaps someone, far ahead, in an unknown tongue, will gather all these stories. Perhaps we live now for that gathering."

He sees Gaurī too. Honestly, he admits he saw Gaurī herself — in another time, another calamity, another eye like hers. The story and the vow will not end with her; they return with more names, more faces, until no name is left for the crocodile to eat, because each is already safe.

● *Why time bends here*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Deliberate non-linearity: 1885, 1934, 1977 and now leap in one kabaddī turn.
- Not mere style — the structural form of the novel's claim that injustice and witness recur.
- The reader is meant to read Vol-0 (past) and Vol-1-2 (present) in one moment.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -85

The Amil's Order

आमिलक आदेश *Āmilak Ādeś*

"The officer's order is on paper, the village's justice on the leaf — an order can be erased; a folk-verse cannot."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Yaśpati returns with the state — this time the witness-tree itself is the target

The axe, and the voice that stops it

The Amil's Order • आमिलक आदेश — card 1 of 2

The proclamation. Amil Jaysingh arrives on elephant with ten soldiers and Yaśpati. The pīpal "witness-tree" is declared a center of tantric superstition: it will be inspected, and if no supernatural power is found, felled and replaced by a royal granary. Yaśpati gloats: "You survived by women's sentiment; today I bring science and the power of the state."

The trap, either way. Jaysingh, neutral, almost kind: "If there is truly a power, my axe won't harm it. If not, you are freed of a lie." Phulesarī whispers it is a trap — lose and the tree falls, win and the burden of proof is theirs. The first axe strikes the root.

"Stop." A voice rises — neither man's nor woman's, as if from a thousand throats — and Būṛhbā's form appears, clear in daylight for the first time. "I keep the names your court's records never held. Fell this tree and you prove the state can cut down whatever it cannot understand — a proof as dangerous to your king as any superstition." Jaysingh orders the axe down.

● The state at the root

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

- Amil Jaysingh — a genuine inquirer, neither villain nor savior
- Yaśpati — returned with the state's power
- Būṛhbā — the witness, seen at last in daylight
- Gaurī — with her daughter Sāvitrī, the next sensitive heir

Yaśpati vanishes, and a new fear

The Amil's Order • आमिलक आदेश — card 2 of 2

The real motive exposed. Jaysingh sees Yaśpati's true aim was the quarter's land, not the tree, and is displeased. Both his weapons — superstition and administrative logic — collapse. Yaśpati flees into the dark forest and vanishes; the frightened soldiers do not stop him.

The power named. Humbled, Jaysingh pledges royal protection for Gaurī's land, tree and rights, and asks what power lives in the tree. Gaurī: "No tantra, no god — only this: if a person, from love, decides never to forget anyone's name, that decision can become stronger than time." His report is later found in no archive — erased, like a witness's name.

The blind spot. But Būṛhbā, alone with Gaurī, voices a fear she has never heard: "I could not see Yaśpati's end. My sight, which now reaches beyond time, stops where he entered the forest. This is unusual. This frightens me."

● Reform vs. local tradition

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- "Superstition-eradication" has often destroyed marginalized communities' autonomous traditions.
- Their real functions — memory, justice, healthcare — go unseen.
- No simple answer: the state's inquirer turns from destruction to acceptance.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -84

The Silence of the Forest

जंगलक मौन *Jaṅgalak Maun*

"The forest stays silent, yet hears everything — one who reads the silence, even the forest speaks to."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The search for Yaśpati — an ending that leaves more questions than answers

A track that ends at the water

The Silence of the Forest • जंगलक मौन — card 1 of 1

The blind fog. A search party enters the dense, shunned forest where the Kamalā-Balān meets a nameless river — water unfathomably deep, home to crocodiles older and larger than the pond's. Būṛhbā is uneasy: "My sight, which now reaches beyond time, blurs at a certain part of that forest. For the first time I know there are things I, with all my witness-power, cannot see."

The vanishing prints. They find a torn piece of Yaśpati's costly silk, then footprints — clear, running, then blurring — that stop at the river's edge: no sign of entering the water, no struggle, no body. Only a half-sunk shoe, and beside it a huge mark, as of a large heavy creature lately slipping into the water. "A crocodile — no ordinary crocodile."

Sorrow cannot save a name. The village receives the news with mixed feeling — even grief, for the man Yaśpati once might have been. Būṛhbā: "His name I cannot save, for saving a name needs love, and for him I have only sorrow. One who shares, receives; one who steals names, his own name is finally safe in no hand." Far off, across the nameless river, something neither Gaurī nor Būṛhbā could ever see slowly opens its eyes and begins to wait.

● The unanswered thread

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Yaśpati's fate is deliberately left open — neither shown dead nor alive.
- Būṛhbā's witness-power is never complete; there is always a corner he cannot see.
- This limit keeps the story realist — no witness is omniscient.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -83

Sonmā the Fisherwoman

सोनमा माझिन *Sonmā Mājhin*

"The net is her hand, the river her mother — the fisherwoman catches fish, but lets the name go free."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A third memory-tradition enters — the fisherfolk's, and the concept of the "Mūl Gohi"

The primal crocodile, and forgetting as nature

Sonmā the Fisherwoman · सोनमा माझिन — card 1 of 1

The hunger reawakened. A month after Yaśpati vanishes, livestock vanish from the pond's edge — no sound, no blood, only a huge drag-mark toward the water. Būṛhbā fears what took Yaśpati has awakened, with a hunger older than his witness-power, and recalls a name the old fishermen once whispered: "Mūl Gohi" — the primal crocodile.

Sonmā's tradition. He sends Gaurī to Sonmā the fisherwoman — blind, serene, whom death itself forgot for her patience. Her ancestors, of no caste the scriptures name, held that water is a living being whose oldest, hungriest child is forgetting itself. They did not fight it: each full moon they offered flowers, fruit, milk — "I do not deny you, but I ask you for patience" — and it slept.

The offering silenced, the hunger stirring. When the new castes came, they called the offering "tantric superstition" — exactly as Yaśpati called Gaurī's herbs. The offerings stopped; the hunger grew slowly, for centuries. Sonmā's message: witness and acceptance are two different acts. To try to stop forgetting entirely is to deny that everything returns to it. The real work is that before forgetting, each name receives its due honour — kept by balance, not by war.

● A third road

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A fisher/water folk-tradition — neither Brahminical nor the Camār herbal one.
- The crocodile belongs to no sect: a deep, multi-layered folk memory.
- Witness-mode (Būṛhbā) and acceptance-mode (Sonmā) are both needed, not opposites.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT • PIVOT

Chapter -82

The First Kabaddī

पहिल कबड्डी *Pahil Kabaddī*

"Go in one breath, return in one breath, touch and come back — kabaddī teaches presence, not capture."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The birth of the name-saving ritual the reader already met in Vol-1-2's Channā grove

Witness and offering, joined in one game

The First Kabaddī • पहिल कबड्डी — card 1 of 1

Sāvitṛī's synthesis. Three years on, Sāvitṛī (16, sharper than her mother) unites two things: Būṛhbā's name-saving and Sonmā's offering. A kabaddī where each raid into the opponent's ground must carry a forgotten name — cross the line with the name and the raid is "won." Not mere play: each raid a small offering, showing the Mūl Gohi that names are brought willingly, with honour, not stolen unwilling.

The first raid. On the new-moon night she raids: "Subhāgī, who found no name in the flood, I bring your name!" Then "Yaśpati — what you became was your choice, but who you once might have been, I too won't forget." The water surges; she stands: "This is fear, not attack. It is listening."

The pact. Third, calming it: "Mūl Gohi, I do not deny you — I ask for patience, as my ancestors did. Each new moon I bring names, willingly; in return, do not steal, only accept." The water stills, as of a vast tired creature breathing easy at last. From that night the ritual becomes a sacred remembrance — and, far ahead, the Channā grove's immortal kabaddī of the dead.

● A central pivot of Vol-0

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The Vol-1–2 "name-saving kabaddī" is born here, in its first form.
- Synthesis of witness + offering + children's play into one ritual.
- Truth and justice are cumulative, inter-generational — no one tradition's property.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -81

The Shadow of Invasion

आक्रमणक छाया *Ākramaṇak Chāyā*

"A shadow grown large is not a larger fear — one steady in his name does not fear his own shadow."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The Turk army at the border — and the ritual that shields the living, not only the dead

Children at play turn an army aside

The Shadow of Invasion • आक्रमणक छाया — card 1 of 1

The army. Twenty years on, the new-moon kabaddī is woven into village life. Then a dust-cloud at the border: a Turk army advancing, Simraongarh's king fled, villages burning. Būṛhbā's sight cannot read human war clearly, but he counsels: hide the old, sick and young; an army after cities won't linger over a poor village unless it is in the way.

Kabaddī, out of season. Late that night, strayed soldiers come to loot. Indumatī hears Būṛhbā: "Play kabaddī tonight, though it is not new moon." The soldiers reach the edge and see children by lamplight, fearlessly shouting "kabaddī-kabaddī" — so ordinary and unafraid that they judge the village mad or empty, for no one in real danger plays so calmly. The captain moves on; the village is untouched.

Firmness violence cannot read. Būṛhbā: "My work was never only saving the dead. One who stands firm on his name and memory, without fear, shows a confidence violence often cannot understand, and so leaves alone." But relief is brief — Simraongarh has fallen; Mithilā's old royal order, the shadow under which every tale from Keśava to Jaysingh unfolded, is over.

● *History as backdrop*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Early-14th-c. Mithilā: the Karnāṭa dynasty falls; Delhi-Sultanate raids on Tirhut.
- Local traditions keep their meaning — and sometimes their use — amid upheaval.
- Vol-0's story now enters a new historical age.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -80

The First Line of the Song

गीतक पहिल पाँति *Gītak Pahil Pānti*

"One throat lifts the song's first line, the village takes up the rest — the author is not one; the village is the maker."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The Oinwar age of Maithili letters — and the tale's first attempt to leave the oral and reach paper

The tale first set on paper — in plain speech

The First Line of the Song • गीतक पहिल पाँति — card 1 of 1

A new age of letters. The Oinwar dynasty brings stability and a new enthusiasm for literature; Maithili rises from a home-and-field language to a language of court and poetry. A wandering poet-collector, Haripati, roams gathering folk-tales, believing Maithili's real power lies in ordinary mouths, not the court's Sanskrit-laced verse.

Būṛhbā's condition. He hears the sākṣī-vṛkṣa and kabaddī story and wants to make it an epic. Būṛhbā's condition: if written, not for honour, not in the court's ornate language — that would repeat the injustice these lives suffered — but in plain village speech, as they actually spoke. Haripati agrees, and writes his first line at the root: "There was a tree, a pond, and a servant who saved names..."

Kept for a later world. He will not show it at court ("the court won't understand it"); he keeps it for a disciple, to preserve but never publish until the world can both hear and understand it. Būṛhbā: "A tale once honestly set on paper never wholly dies, however many centuries go unread." That first line will be rewritten far ahead — another age, a computer screen — under the title गोहि सभक बीच जलसमाधि.

● The novel's own question

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Oinwar rule (14th–15th c.): the golden age of Maithili literature.
- Can folk-tales of the marginalized be "high literature"? — the novel's own question.
- And the founding question of Videha and the Parallel Literature Movement.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -79

The Raid of Forgiveness

क्षमाक पारी *Kṣamāk Pārī*

"Whom you touch in kabaddī, you give a turn to return — forgiveness too is a raid, not revenge."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The kabaddī played, for the first time, for a living man's old family crime

A grandson returns what was taken

The Raid of Forgiveness • क्षमाक पारी — card 1 of 1

The burden of an inherited crime. Forty-five years on, the ritual has passed Indumatī → Śāradā → Vasundharā. An old man in torn but costly clothes comes to the quarter's gate: Raghuvīr, grandson of Pratāpsen Ṭhākur, come to seek forgiveness before dying — carrying his grandfather's sin, though "the crime was not mine."

A new kind of raid. Būṛhbā: saving names is not only keeping the dead's memory — it is giving the living a chance to set their story right while alive. That new moon, Vasundharā tells Raghuvīr: today you won't take a name, you'll be one — "Raghuvīr, who came to acknowledge his family's crime" — and we'll remember it as we do Sukhdev's and Hulāsā's. He weeps, and returns a piece of land his grandfather wrongly took.

"A step toward truth." "This cannot buy forgiveness," he says, "but it is a step toward truth." Būṛhbā comes down from the root and, for the first time, tries to lay a hand on a living man's head (staying a finger above): "Your grandfather's name I hold with sorrow; yours, from today, with respect. The difference seems small, but it holds the whole value." The village calls him not "Ṭhākur-criminal" but "Raghuvīr, who returned."

● Inherited guilt, careful mercy

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Is a descendant answerable for an ancestor's crime?
The story gives no fixed answer.
- The land-return is "a step toward truth," deliberately left incomplete.
- The ritual now has a role for the living, repentant — keeping acceptance distinct from forgiveness.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -78

Outside the Panjī

पंजीक बाहर *Panjik Bāhar*

"One whose name is not in the register is not outside the village — whom paper abandoned, the earth took as its own."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Mithilā's genealogical register enters the tale — and the question of whose names it holds

A shadow-register for the names left out

Outside the Panjī • पंजीक बाहर — card 1 of 1

The register, and its boundary. Mithilā's ancient Panjī Prabandh records the lineages, marriages and status of Brahmin and Kārṇa-Kāyastha households — a pillar of social memory, but standing only for some. Camār, fisher and other marginalized communities' names never entered it, as if they lived beyond an invisible line.

The panjīkār's question. A young, dutiful register-keeper, Yādavānand Jhā, shelters in the village when his horse falls ill, and — by coincidence on a new-moon night — is taken to the pīpal. Watching Vasundharā attach a small story to each name (Ratnā, Somar, Mālatī, Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Subhāgī, Gaurī), he is stunned: "My whole life served a register of thousands of names — that holds not one of your quarter. I never asked what kind of justice that is."

Two registers. Būṛhbā opens his voice to the outsider: "Your panjī records lineage and status; my memory records truth and love. Both are needed — but if only the first stands, half of Mithilā's memory stays in darkness." At dawn Yādavānand takes out his personal notebook and records three hours of names — a "shadow-panjī," unofficial, perhaps forever, but safe on paper as long as he lives.

● Whose memory is recorded

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The Panjī Prabandh, admired for its scholarship, historically held mainly two communities.
- Most of Mithilā — Shudra, Dalit, Adivasi — stayed outside the official memory.
- The "shadow-panjī" is a fictional but pointed answer — the counter-canon in miniature.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -77

Būr̥hbā's Silence

बूढ़बाक मौन *Būr̥hbāk Maun*

"When Būr̥hbā is silent, he speaks the most — silence too is an answer."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The witness himself begins to break — and the village learns that a witness, too, needs to be witnessed

The witness who was never witnessed

Būṛhbā's Silence • बूढ़बाक मौन — card 1 of 1

The failing voice. Ten years on, the ritual passes to Kauśalyā. Būṛhbā's voice — once clear and ready — grows slow, tired, sometimes wholly silent. One new-moon he does not come. A faint voice: "Forgive me. I can't remember the names tonight... Hulāsā, or Hulāsī... Sukhdev, or Surendra... I fear I am forgetting. The very work I was born for is slipping from me."

The question never asked. Sonmā's descendant Godāvarī asks what no one had: "You asked Būṛhbā for thousands of names over the years. Did you ever speak his own name — Budhuā — with full honour? Did you ever mourn for him, sing for him, as he did for thousands?" The truth lands: Budhuā always gave, never received.

The raid for Būṛhbā. That night the whole village — every quarter, without distinction — gathers, and plays the kabaddī for Būṛhbā's own name. One by one they retell his story: his service, his water-burial, his helplessness in the first flood, his sorrow for Yaśpati. A steady light rises. "Being a witness is not a one-way act. One-way, it empties the witness. Flowing both ways, it can go on forever."

● Reciprocity

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A portrait of "compassion fatigue" — the one-way carrier is finally depleted.
- A new annual custom: the Phāgun-full-moon "Būṛhbā-smaraṇ," retelling his story.
- Witness, justice and memory can't rest on one person — the burden must be shared.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -76

The First Lesson on the Coconut Leaf

नारिकेल पातक पहिल पाठ *Nārikel Pātak Pahil Pāṭh*

"The first lesson on the leaf — how a name is written — the leaf that holds the name, the tree that holds the history."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The origin of the Nārikel-pāt Pāṭhaśālā — a Vol-1 institution born of scarcity

Writing their own story, at last

The First Lesson on the Coconut Leaf • नारिकेल पातक पहिल पाठ — card 1 of 1

A story in another's hand. Kauśalyā's daughter Mandākinī feels a discontent: the quarter's history is now safe on paper and in the shadow-panjī, but no one in the quarter can read the letters written for them. "Our story is in another's hand, not in our own eyes." The Brahmin school takes only upper-caste boys; paper and palm-leaf are costly.

The coconut leaf. Idly drawing on a dried coconut leaf, she finds the line shows clearly — the leaf's inner-green and outer-dry layers give a natural contrast that needs no ink. In Gaṛh Nārikel, coconut trees are the one thing never scarce. She and her friends begin first lessons in the quarter's open ground — boys and girls, no caste bar (even poor Brahmin families send children).

Both guardians. Būṛhbā: "This is the next step of our whole story — Hulāsā couldn't get her name on the copy; your children will write their own." But when Mandākinī asks if the ritual is now needed less, he answers: "Writing and witnessing are two acts. What is written can be burned or torn; what is remembered with love, mouth to mouth, is harder to destroy. You need both — as guardians of each other."

● Scarcity as parent of innovation

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Local free material (coconut leaf) makes education accessible — historically real.
- The Vol-1 institution "Nārikel-pāt Pāṭhaśālā" gets its origin here.
- Modern institutions are the continuity of old need, not sudden invention.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -75

The First Rebellion of Reason

तर्कक पहिल विद्रोह *Tarkak Pahil Vidroh*

"The one who asked did not defeat the teacher, but woke him — reason's first rebellion, knowledge's first dawn."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The school's own fruit — a literate generation now questions its oldest tradition

Doubt, and the mark by the water

The First Rebellion of Reason • तर्कक पहिल विद्रोह — card 1 of 1

The doubter. Educated at a town school in logic and mathematics, Mandākinī's great-grandson Viśvanāth returns full of questions. After a kabaddī he tells the guardian: "I no longer believe in this game. Būṛhbā, the Mūl Gohi — perhaps our ancestors' imagination, not the real reason we survived." The new-moon crowd shrinks for the first time in centuries.

Būṛhbā's patience. Būṛhbā is not saddened: "He is not wrong to ask — that is the very work Vācaspati, Udayana, Gaṅgeśa did. But I know one thing he does not yet." Months later, livestock vanish again from the nameless water while the ritual is weak. Viśvanāth goes to prove a natural cause — and finds the same huge, unexplainable mark by the water.

Respect without belief. He returns to the pīpal: "To reject a tradition that has kept the village safe for years — without an alternative safeguard — isn't wisdom, it's arrogance." Būṛhbā: "Accept honestly what you saw, then decide for yourself." Viśvanāth returns to the kabaddī: "I don't fully understand it, but I'll continue with respect until I find a better answer."

● Science and tradition

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A universal tension: education's rational outlook vs. experience-based folk-knowledge.
- Neither side wholly right — the doubt is valid, the forest's evidence undeniable.
- "Faith and respect aren't the same, but both can do the same work."



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -74

The Tree's Disease

गाछक रोग *Gāchak Rog*

"Tend one leaf's disease, or it spreads through the tree — a village's sickness too begins with one silence."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The witness-tree sickens — and Būṛhbā admits he too rests on a physical basis

All quarters heal the witness-tree

The Tree's Disease • गाछक रोग — card 1 of 1

The sickness. The centuries-old pīpal grows old; its northern branch yellows and dark wet spots mark the bark. Kedar (the ritual now given by merit to women and men alike) asks if it affects Būṛhbā. "Yes. I am bound to this tree as your body to your breath. Perhaps its life is now completing." The village panics: if the tree dies, who holds the names?

Old knowledge and new. Kedar — heir to both Viśvanāth's reason and his grandmothers' reverence — brings a town tree-doctor: pests are hollowing the bark, curable with patient care. Every quarter works together — Sonmā's line teaches the traditional root-treatment, the tree-doctor the modern method, and the coconut-leaf-school children keep a daily health-record of each branch. Month by month, the tree heals.

Fragility acknowledged. Būṛhbā: "I kept reminding you no body is immortal — but I forgot that I too am bound to a body, this tree. Being a witness is not immortality, only a long, fragile thread needing constant care." The village's new duty: reverence is not enough; the tree needs practical, continuous care. "To serve Būṛhbā is not only to save names, but to let the tree live."

● Caring for a living monument

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A living monument needs not only reverence but continuous, practical care.
- Best done by combining modern knowledge (tree science) and traditional (herbal).
- Immortality, however vast, is never fully burden-free.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -73

Mohan's Melody

मोहनक धुन *Mohanak Dhun*

"The flute's melody melts into the air, yet the ear keeps it — a tune that touches the heart is not forgotten."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Grief turned to art — the origin of the chapter-opening folk-song device of Vol-1

A name that becomes a sound

Mohan's Melody · मोहनक धुन — card 1 of 1

The loss. In Śīlāvatī's time the quarter's finest musician is Mohan (Somar's seventh-generation descendant). One winter his four-year-old daughter Rādhikā dies of fever, her small hand gripping his finger. For weeks his house is silent — no weeping, no music.

The melody. One evening he takes his drum to the pīpal and plays a faint, sorrowful rhythm — neither wholly dirge nor lullaby. "I want her name to be not just a word, but a sound, so that hearing it, a heart knows this name was full of love." Śīlāvatī asks him to tie melodies to the ritual: a small tune for each story — Hulāsā's tender and breaking mid-way, Sukhdev's slow then suddenly still, Ratnā's warm and motherly.

Transformation, not disrespect. "Is it disrespect to turn her grief into music?" Būṛhbā: "I saved names with words, you with melody — both give love a form that can cross time. Your grief was not disrespected; it was transformed — and transformation, for memory, is the opposite of disrespect." Rādhikā's melody opens each new-moon ritual — a reminder that the game is about love, not competition.

● Grief into folk-song

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Transforming personal grief into art — a common origin of folk-music.
- Far ahead this becomes the "adhyāyārambha lokgīt" — a song opening each chapter.
- This chapter is itself opened by such a song in the source — the device's own origin-tale.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -72

The Marriage Witness

विवाहक साक्षी *Vivāhak Sākṣī*

"In marriage the fire is witness, the village is witness, the name is witness — whose wedding the village saw, their vow is on the leaf."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A cross-caste marriage echoing Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī — but this time celebrated openly

A new hope, not a new tragedy

The Marriage Witness • विवाहक साक्षी — card 1 of 1

The echo of Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī. Śīlāvatī's granddaughter Anurādhā and a Brahmin-quarter youth, Gopīnāth — childhood friends from the coconut-leaf school — wish to marry. Anurādhā: "My ancestors know how Gaṅgeśa married Mālatī, and how society forgot that marriage, remembering only his scripture. I don't want my story forgotten like that."

The question the pandit can't answer. Gopīnāth's father, a respected pandit, first opposes it. At the pīpal Būṛhbā asks: "Every great tragedy of this village was tied to the line drawn between caste and class. Why raise that line again for your son, when he himself wants to break it?" "I fear what people will say." "What people say changes with time; the names I hold do not. Your choice — add a new tragedy to that list, or a new hope?"

The whole village celebrates. The pandit agrees; both quarters prepare together. At the pīpal, Mohan's descendants compose a festive melody without a shadow of sorrow — a first for the tradition. Būṛhbā: "I was witness to Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī though not present; today I witness yours directly, and vow your love-story will be held with the same honour — a tale not of sorrow but of joy."

● How change actually comes

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Social change in caste is never sudden — it is cumulative, inter-generational.
- Explicitly closes the circle opened by Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī (–91).
- What was once suppressed and forgotten can, at last, be accepted openly and with joy.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -71

The Night of the Epidemic

महामारीक राति *Mahāmārik Rāti*

"The epidemic took the body, not the song — the night the village stayed awake together saved the dawn."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An epidemic overwhelms the old method — and forces a new way to remember the many

When the dead are too many to name one by one

The Night of the Epidemic • महामारीक राति — card 1 of 1

The plague. Ten years after Anurādhā and Gopīnāth's marriage, a disease comes from the east — high fever, black lumps, death within three days. Seventeen die in one week. Anurādhā's daughter Vimalā despairs: the kabaddī is monthly, but with so many names, how can each get its story, its melody, its time, when death comes so fast?

Two answers, old and new. The healer (the tree-doctor's disciple) brings measures he can't fully explain but whose effect shows — quarantine the sick, boil water, burn the dead's belongings. And Vimalā and Būṛhbā create "collective remembrance": each dawn the survivors call all the night's dead in one voice, without individual detail but with full honour.

Numbers are forgotten; names are not. As effective as the old way: "The depth of love is not measured by the number of words." A third of the village dies, from every quarter. Asked how many names she held, Vimalā wonders — thousands? Būṛhbā: "I never counted, and never will. If number matters, I become its slave and each name's uniqueness is lost. Numbers are forgotten; names are not."

● *A tradition that bends to survive*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The challenge every memory-tradition faces: too many dead for individual remembrance.
- "Collective remembrance" mirrors real mourning-forms after epidemics and disasters.
- A tradition survives by keeping its core feeling while making its form flexible.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT • KEYSTONE

Chapter -70

The Planting of the Channā Grove

चन्ना गाछीक रोपाई *Channā Gāchīk Ropāī*

"A newly planted tree gives no shade in a day — be patient; the root takes hold first, the leaves after."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The origin of the Channā grove — the central place of the whole novel

A living library of names

The Planting of the Channā Grove · चन्ना गाछीक रोपाई — card 1 of 1

A tree for every memory. After the epidemic, Vimalā begins a new tradition: for every great sorrow or hope, plant a tree — for the epidemic's dead, for Hulāsā and Jīvantī, Sukhdev and Ratnā, Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī — until a whole grove rings the pīpal. Būṛhbā asks: which tree? A travelled farmer suggests the Channā — fast-growing, deep-shading, its leaves rustling faintly even at night, "because its rustle never fully stills, just as memory never fully stills."

The grove grows. Tree by tree, year by year, each generation adds one for its new memory — even Yaśpati's (smallest, at the very edge, a mark of complex memory). A dense, shady grove forms, mysteriously alive at night as if each tree whispers its story. The village calls it "Channā gāchī," and it becomes a permanent part of the village's geography.

One tree, then a whole grove. Būṛhbā feels newly extended — bound now not to one tree but to every root. "A single tree can sicken or fall; a whole grove is never wholly destroyed — always some root survives. You have given me, unknowing, a body safer than one tree." The grove becomes the village's holiest place — the pīpal its heart, a living library read not by letters but by reverence and memory.

● Where the novel is rooted

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The origin of Vol-1-2's central site — the Channā gāchī.
- Memory-tree-planting is a real practice across many cultures.
- Memory concentrated in one place is fragile; distributed and collective, it endures.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -69

The Tale of the Elephant and the Crocodile

गज-ग्राहक कथा *Gaj-Grāhak Kathā*

"Elephant in the water, crocodile in the water — the fight lasts years — but the hand that calls the name brings deliverance."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Gajendra-mokṣa meets the local Mūl Gohi — the origin of the "gaj-grāh" motif

Prayer and effort, never one alone

The Tale of the Elephant and the Crocodile • गज-ग्राहक कथा — card 1 of 1

The grip. In Sūryanāth's time the temple elephant Gajarāj wades into the pond's deep part, and a huge crocodile — which had not touched an animal for ages, thanks to Sonmā's offering — grips his leg. The crowd freezes. An old pandit cries: "This is Gajendra-mokṣa! Gajendra struggled for ages and could not free himself by strength — only when he abandoned all ego and called on God was he saved. We must pray!"

Both, together. Būṛhbā: "The pandit is right — but prayer alone is not enough, just as logic alone is not enough. We need both." The village does two things at once — loud collective prayer (the Gajendra verse and the ritual's own call to the Mūl Gohi), while strong youths, with rope and bamboo, patiently work the gripped leg free from an angle, without directly challenging the crocodile.

The grip loosens. After long struggle the crocodile suddenly releases and vanishes into the deep, as if it knew this fight was not its own. Gajarāj reaches shore, weak but alive. Būṛhbā: "The ancient tale and my local tradition are one truth in two languages — freedom from a grip, of water or of mind, never comes alone."

● Strength and surrender

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Joins the Bhāgavata's Gajendra-mokṣa with the local Mūl Gohi tradition.
- Great classical and local oral traditions often speak one deep truth in two languages.
- "Gaj-grāh" — met in Vol-1 as a metaphor for modern grips — gets its literal origin here.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -68

The Court's First Hearing

अदालतक पहिल तारीख *Adālatak Pahil Tārikh*

"Date upon date, but justice is on the leaf — the court asks after the body; the village keeps the name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A formal court arrives — and with it the slow hunger that becomes the "court's ghost"

The injustice of the date

The Court's First Hearing · अदालतक पहिल तारीख — card 1 of 1

The new court. In Kamalinī's time a formal court — brick building, appointed judge, written law — replaces the old informal assembly. First welcomed, for written law gives all equal rights regardless of caste. But filing is easy and verdicts come slowly: a simple dispute that took a day now hangs for years, postponed on technicalities.

The hunger called "tārīkh." The poor farmer Bhola waits three years on "next date," wasting workdays. An old lawyer tells him: "This court has a hunger we call the date — made of paper, but it eats a person's time, patience, sometimes a whole life." Būṛhbā recalls Sukhdev dying in the water-clock queue: the court looks different, but the root problem is the same — time made an obstacle to justice, not its tool.

A new kind of ghost. Būṛhbā: "This system, for all its good intent, is birthing a ghost made not of one person's injustice but of the whole system's slowness — the very soul of delay." Kamalinī can't change the law, but resolves to give every villager caught in it help and company. Bhola wins after five years — his field long ruined, his children grown hungry.

● Justice delayed

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A contemporary problem in historical dress: procedural delay as denial of justice.
- Plants the seed of Vol-1-2's "court's ghost" — deemed worse than the crocodile.
- Institutional injustice can arise from structural failings, not personal malice.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -67

The Call of the Foreign Land

परदेशक पुकार *Pardeśak Pukār*

"The foreign land gives wealth and takes the name — one the village remembers is not lost even abroad."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The first recruiter at the gate — indenture, and memory across distance

How memory reaches beyond the grove

The Call of the Foreign Land • परदेशक पुकार — card 1 of 1

The recruiter. In Jānakī's time a recruiter comes to the gate — sweet tongue, shiny clothes, a bundle of papers: "Work abroad! Three-year contract, good wages, then home!" Bhola's grandson Rāmsevak, seeing his family's hardship, presses his thumbprint on a paper he cannot read.

A token at the root. His mother fears: thousands of miles away, how will his name be saved? Būṛhbā admits he does not know how far his witness reaches. Jānakī fills the gap: for everyone who leaves, a small stone or thread at the pīpal root, and each new-moon their name is called — alive or dead, news or none — so the name stays safe here, wherever the body is. The custom "pardeśak pukār" is born.

Only silence. Rāmsevak never returns; no letter, no message, only silence. His mother comes each new-moon to touch his token. "Is my son alive or dead?" Būṛhbā, honestly: "I don't know; I won't lie. But I vow to hold his name, alive or dead, returning or not. Distance cannot erase a name — only lengthen uncertainty." The tradition first learns to think beyond its own geography.

● *Memory across distance*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- An early signal of colonial "girmitiya" indenture — many taken abroad, never to return.
- How can witness work across geographical distance? — the question raised.
- It echoes forward into Vol-1-2's migrant-worker and digital-scam strands.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -66

The Women's Night-Assembly

स्त्री सभक राति-सभा *Strī Sabhak Rāti-Sabhā*

"Where women's voices gather, the darkness thins — the night-assembly breaks the dark even without a lamp."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The chaunki-circle, informal for generations, at last takes a formal shape

Out of the chaunki's dark, into the light

The Women's Night-Assembly • स्त्री सभक राति-सभा — card 1 of 1

The court's blind spot. In Sulochanā's time the new court fails women — domestic disputes, dowry, inheritance, a husband's abuse go unheard, or are judged from far outside women's experience. Padmā, beaten for years, seeks justice; the judge waves it off: "A domestic matter — settle it outside court." She returns unheard.

Formalizing the circle. Būṛhbā recalls Ratnā, Gaurī, Phulesarī — women who gathered after dusk on the chaunki to share knowledge, justice, strategy, because the official assembly would not hear them. "That tradition never ended, only stayed informal. Perhaps now is the time to make it formal." Sulochanā founds the "women's night-assembly," parallel to the court.

One voice. In Padmā's case, every village woman testifies — the bruises seen, the weeping heard. The husband's family denies, but when the whole women's society speaks in one voice, they must yield: reform, or Padmā is free to leave with the village's support. Būṛhbā: "Women's knowledge and justice now step out of the chaunki's darkness into the village's light, standing with their own name."

● A parallel justice

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- When formal, male-dominated justice fails women, parallel women's systems arise.
- A strong, positive culmination of the chaunki-circle (the "seed of the witch," -91).
- What fear once called "ḍāin" becomes, at last, a recognized institution of justice.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -65

The Procession of the Fake Ghost

नकली भूतक जुलूस *Naklī Bhūtak Julūs*

"A fake ghost frightens only one who has forgotten his name — one steady in his name laughs at the ghost's procession."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The first misuse of Būṛhbā's name — and the test that separates a true witness from a fraud

"A true witness never asks for money"

The Procession of the Fake Ghost • नकली भूतक जुलूस — card 1 of 1

The imitation. The fame of the ritual has spread — and with fame comes imitation. A wandering man, Kālīcaran, tours nearby villages calling himself "Būṛhbā's real spirit," leading night processions with hired "ghosts" (cloth-wrapped, lamp-bearing assistants) and extorting money for a "special pūjā" to save names. A cheated family comes to meet the real Būṛhbā.

Not a failure of the tradition. Būṛhbā: "Whatever is true and valuable, someone opportunistic will find profit in imitating. This is not my tradition's failure — it is a sad byproduct of its success."

The simple test. "There is a clear line between a true witness and a false claim. A true witness never asks for money, never profits by selling fear. It asks only for a name, and gives love and memory in return — nothing else." Harinandan spreads the test; Kālīcaran's racket collapses and he vanishes. The tale survives as a warning: one who claims to witness but asks for money is a thief.

● A test against exploitation

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- When a respected tradition grows famous, opportunists arise to exploit the credulous.
- "A true witness never asks for money" — a practical, universal principle.
- The title appears directly in Vol-1; its origin is here.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -64

Sukhdev's Requital

सुखदेवक बदला *Sukhdevak Badlā*

"Revenge is a fire — it first burns your own hand — one who chose forgiveness saved the village."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The land-injustice begun with Sukhdev (-92) reaches its opposite outcome

Requital as justice, not revenge

Sukhdev's Requital • सुखदेवक बदला — card 1 of 1

History returns. Under a new land-survey, a zamindar, Raghubīr Singh, claims the Camār quarter's land — as Ugrasen once did in Sukhdev's time. But Campāvati does not panic: "I have a weapon Sukhdev's time did not."

Centuries of accumulated capacity. She goes to the archive for Yādavānand's "shadow-panjī" — recording the quarter's land-rights with dates and witnesses from Somar and Ratnā's time. The coconut-leaf-school's young lawyers prepare the case; the women's night-assembly unites the village in public support; Haripati's old book is entered as evidence. Raghubīr Singh, with no solid proof, loses. The judge: "Such a detailed, consistent record is proof of the village's own historical consciousness."

No single miracle. Būṛhbā: "Today I saw Sukhdev's requital — not as revenge, but as justice. It happened by generations of accumulated effort — Yādavānand's notebook, Haripati's book, Mandākinī's school, Sulochanā's night-assembly — all bearing fruit at once. No struggle is in vain, if its memory stays alive."

● The power of accumulated capacity

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The land-injustice opened by Sukhdev's tragedy (–92) reaches its opposite outcome.
- Literacy, documentation, legal knowledge, women's unity — built over centuries.
- Long-term social investment protects justice better than individual heroism.



The First Page of the Printing Press

छापाखानाक पहिल पन्ना *Chāpākhānāk Pahil Pannā*

"The first printed page — a name is now hard to erase — what is printed, the whole village will read."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Print arrives — and Būṛhbā decides the still-growing story must wait

The story that is not yet finished

The First Page of the Printing Press • छपाखानाक पहिल पन्ना — card 1 of 1

The marvel. A printing press opens in the nearby town, printing in Maithili and Hindi — a machine making hundreds of identical pages in a day. Haripati Gaṅgādhara (the poet's seventh-generation descendant), now a writer-publisher, has inherited the secret palm-leaf book of Būṛhbā's story and rushes to the village: "Now I can print it! It can never be lost, however many centuries pass!"

Būṛhbā's caution. After a long silence: "If printed today, it is still incomplete. Subhāgī, Yaśpati, Padmā, Rāmsevak — many names are still being added. To print now would close the story in a fixed form while it is still alive, still growing. Perhaps the time for its printing has not yet come."

Kept for the right time. Gaṅgādhara understands, and vows that he and his descendants will preserve the book until the story is truly complete — then some descendant will print it for the whole world. Meanwhile he prints the village's smaller books — the school's curriculum, the night-assembly's rules, the farming lore — but Būṛhbā's whole story stays oral, alive.

● A story aware of itself

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Print's arrival — a revolution for Indian-language literature.
- The story knows it is not yet complete, and chooses to keep growing.
- An early echo of the eventual publication of गोहि सभक बीच जलसमाधि itself.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -62

Waiting for Relief

राहतक प्रतीक्षा *Rāhatak Pratīkṣā*

"Eyes tire watching the road for relief, yet the village stands — where all watch together, even waiting is lighter."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A colonial-era famine — and the difference between waiting for aid and organizing oneself

Witness and waiting are two different things

Waiting for Relief • राहतक प्रतीक्षा — card 1 of 1

The famine. Under British rule the rains fail utterly. Officials announce relief — grain centers, work-for-grain, medical aid — but the nearest center is twenty kos away and registration so complex that starving families weaken before they can enrol. Sāvitṛidevī: "Help is coming, but it is twenty kos away, and our children are hungry today."

Organizing instead. Būṛhbā: "Waiting, without effort, is itself a kind of death." On the night-assembly's leadership, the village pools a shared grain-store by each family's capacity; the school's youth keep account for equal distribution; a communal kitchen runs by the Channā grove. Sonmā's line teaches new fishing; Ratnā's line identifies wild edible roots. When the relief team arrives three months later, not one life has been lost — while villages that waited suffered greatly.

The lesson proved. "We did not refuse your help," Sāvitṛidevī tells the officer, "we only refused to believe we were helpless without it." Būṛhbā: "To live in memory, I save names; but to live in life, you must act, not wait."

● Self-reliance and mutual aid

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Colonial famine-relief, orderly on paper, often failed through delay and distance.
- Centuries of accumulated social capital kept the community alive without outside aid.
- Waiting without effort is not justice — only delay.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -61

The Comet in the Sky

आकाशक पुच्छलतारा *Ākāśak Pucchaltārā*

"The comet comes and goes; the village stays in place — what shines above does not change the name below."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An omen in the sky — and the calm alertness that sets up a three-fold crisis

The star is a sign, not a cause

The Comet in the Sky • आकाशक पुच्छलतारा — card 1 of 1

The omen. One autumn night an unprecedented long-tailed star creeps across the sky. Villagers, never having seen a comet, are afraid; an old astrologer cries that it foretells a king's death, war, famine, or epidemic. Rudranāth asks Būṛhbā what it means.

A balanced answer. "My sight is sometimes clear, sometimes fogged. Tonight I feel a vague dread of a hard time near. But the star itself brings no calamity — it moves by its own law, unaware of human fate. Any calamity will come from the earth's own causes — water, fire, or disease. The star is only a sign to stay alert, not a cause." Rudranāth orders every quarter to secure grain, keep water clean, report any illness.

Three forms at once. The comet fades after three weeks, but the air grows strangely heavy — as if unseen cloud, fire and water hover together. Būṛhbā, touching each tree of the grove, whispers to the Mūl Gohi: "A great cycle is turning again, as in Hulāsā's and Sukhdev's time — but this time, perhaps, all at once, in three forms."

● Superstition vs. dismissal

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The comet, read as ill omen across many cultures, sets up the story's next stage.
- A balanced path: the star is not guilty, but alertness is warranted.
- It opens a three-fold crisis — fire, flood, epidemic — the village's hardest test.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -60

The Night of Fire

अगिनक राति *Aginak Rāti*

"Fire took the house, not the name — from the ashes of the night that burned, a new hearth was lit."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The first of the three crises — and the grove itself in danger

Memory and organization against the flames

The Night of Fire • अग्निक राति — card 1 of 1

The blaze. A month after the comet, a wind-blown lamp falls on dry straw by the grain-store. Fierce wind carries the fire house to house, quarter to quarter — ten Brahmin-quarter houses, five Kāyastha, part of the temple. Worst, it moves toward the Channā grove.

The human chain. Indrāṇī runs to the grove. Būṛhbā, fear and firmness both: "My power is of memory, not fire. But I recall a way — the twin pond. Turn the water toward the grove." The night-assembly forms a human chain, pond to grove, buckets hand to hand. At the pīpal's root the fire slows — every leaf of the grove seeming to move together, confusing the flames, making them lose their way.

Whose work it was. By dawn the fire is out; a quarter of the houses burned, but the grove survives and the pīpal is unharmed. "Did you stop the fire yourself?" "No. I only knew where the water was. The rest was your hands, your organization, your courage. Memory and organization together can challenge even nature's most terrible power." The village rebuilds with new fire-safety rules.

● Collective action

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The human water-chain is a real, historically effective emergency technique.
- Būṛhbā gives direction; the real work is human collective effort.
- Witness-power is not a substitute for human action, but its complement.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -59

The Second Flood

दोसर बाढ़ि *Dosar Bāṛhi*

"The second flood knows the old path, yet gives a new wound — a village that has borne a flood learns to read the water."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The second of the comet's three crises — and the payoff of accumulated learning

The same flood, a village that learned to read water

The Second Flood • दोसर बाढ़ि — card 1 of 1

The angrier water. Three months after the fire, unrelenting rain bursts the Kamalā-Balān again. The brick embankment — strengthened since Sukhdev's time — trembles. Būṛhbā recalls the first flood in Gaurī's time, when seven died: "Today you are more prepared. But this water seems angrier."

The warning that came first. Indrāṇī reinforces weak sections with sandbags, moves the old and young to high ground beforehand, readies boats and ropes. When the embankment breaks south of the Camār quarter, the warning-system has already fired — bell, drum-melody, pre-arranged signals. Mohan's descendants play the "danger-melody" every villager has known from childhood; each family runs to its pre-assigned safe spot.

Zero deaths. By dawn the water recedes — houses washed away, fields ruined, but not a single life lost, for the first time in village memory in a great flood. Indrāṇī: "Today I repaid Gaurī's debt." Būṛhbā: "This is my greatest gift — to see my memory become, in your hands, a knowledge that saves lives, not only names."

● Early warning saves lives

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Early-warning systems and pre-set evacuation, however simple, cut disaster mortality sharply.
- Measured against the first flood (–89): seven dead then, none now.
- Clear, measurable proof of accumulated institutional learning.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -58

The Third Calamity

तेसर बिपत्ति *Tesar Bipatti*

"The first calamity teaches, the third ripens — one who has fallen thrice stands firm the fourth time."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The comet's third prophecy fulfilled — a water-borne disease closes the triad

Three knowledges against one disease

The Third Calamity • तेसर बिपत्ति — card 1 of 1

The disease. Stagnant pools remain after the flood, and within two weeks a new illness — stomach pain, severe diarrhea, rapid dehydration — spreads among children and elders. Indrāṇī, having fought fire and flood, faces the third test: "I fear whether my people can bear this much."

Modern, traditional, social. The healer (trained at the town's medical school) sees it spreads from dirty water: boil water, and make a salt-sugar solution against dehydration. Sonmā's and Ratnā's lines identify which herbs stop diarrhea and which sources are safe. The women's night-assembly enforces hygiene house to house. In three weeks the disease is controlled — some die, but not devastatingly.

The test, not the end. "I thought the comet came bringing our end." Būṛhbā: "It came bringing a test — to see how strong centuries of accumulated knowledge, organization, and love had become. So strong that three calamities together could not break it." Remembered as "the year of three calamities," with the refrain: "They died in calamity, but the village did not die."

● Multi-dimensional response

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Closes the comet's triad — fire, flood, and water-borne disease (epidemiologically accurate).
- Multi-layered disaster needs modern science, traditional knowledge, and organization together.
- A practical demonstration of Vol-O's message: witness and community action both.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -57

The Sahib's Notebook

साहेबक नोटबुक *Sāhebak Noṭbuk*

"What the sahib wrote is his account — what the village remembers is the village's truth."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A colonial scholar records the village — and gets it wrong

The story told from outside, and from within

The Sahib's Notebook • साहेबक नोटबुक — card 1 of 1

The ethnographer. An English scholar, Mr. Henry Thompson, hears of the famous "year of three calamities" and comes with notebook and pen, questioning every elder — who Būṛhbā is, what kabaddī means, the origin of the Channā grove. He leaves with a thick book, promising publication in England's scholarly society.

The distortion. A year later a copy reaches the village: Būṛhbā is "a relic of primitive superstition," the grove "backward villagers' ghost-worship," the kabaddī "barbaric custom," the night-assembly "local women's uncontrolled behavior." Nandkiśor is furious. Būṛhbā: "He heard my story, but his eye, his language, his viewpoint were not the village's — and in that lens, whatever is unfamiliar looks backward or barbaric."

Definition from within. "Protest, yes — but more important, preserve my own story, in my own language, from my own viewpoint. Stopping outsiders from misunderstanding is not in my hand; understanding ourselves rightly, and keeping our truth in our own words, is." Nandkiśor writes a firm letter (no reply comes) and more carefully compiles the village's own account of itself.

● Self-representation

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A real tendency of colonial ethnography — good intent, but portraying local ways as "primitive."
- A community must write its own story, in its own language and viewpoint.
- This principle is the founding inspiration of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -56

The Call of Freedom

स्वाधीनताक पुकार *Svādhīnatāk Pukār*

"The call that reached village after village was not of one throat — freedom too is a shared song."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The freedom movement reaches the village — and its old arts of organization prove useful

A new kind of kabaddī

The Call of Freedom • स्वाधीनताक पुकार — card 1 of 1

The wave arrives. The freedom movement intensifies across India — salt-satyagraha, the foreign-cloth boycott, non-cooperation — and reaches Garh Nārikel by newspaper and traveller. A young freedom-fighter, Rāmāśray, calls the village to join. Lakṣmīdevī fears British reprisal after so many calamities.

Būṛhbā's counsel. "One who stands for his self-respect, his name — whether he wins or loses — is worth remembering." On the night-assembly's leadership, women burn foreign cloth; youth spin thread and weave khadi; elders carry the movement's word to every house with the kabaddī's discipline and patience.

Firm, nonviolent resistance. When a police squad comes to arrest the activists, the village mounts peaceful but firm resistance — by satyagraha, without violence or retreat. Rāmāśray and some youth are jailed, then freed and welcomed as heroes. Būṛhbā: "A new kind of kabaddī — every villager playing an invisible opponent for their self-respect, and without losing a name, saving all the names."

● Organization applied to politics

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Centuries of community organizing apply to a large political struggle.
- Gandhian satyagraha resonates with the village's own tradition (cf. facing Jaysingh, –85).
- Local and national struggles are driven by the same fundamental values.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -55

The Dawn of Freedom

स्वतंत्रताक भोर *Svatantratāk Bhor*

"Dawn came, but not at once to every courtyard — one whose name is free sees the dawn first."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- India becomes free — and the village enters a new age

Not the answer, but the right to ask

The Dawn of Freedom • स्वतंत्रताक भोर — card 1 of 1

The tricolor rises. On the morning of 15 August, a new sun rises over India and Garh Nārikel. The tricolor is hoisted at the square for the first time; the school-taught children sing the anthem from every throat. Rāmāśray, once jailed and now the village's leader: "We are free, but freedom is only a beginning. The real work — making it meaningful — remains."

Centuries in one silence. Viśvambharnāth asks Būṛhbā what he feels, from Vācaspati's time to the end of British rule. "Each of hundreds of names asked a question — is justice possible? dignity? equality? Freedom's dawn is not the answer, but the recognition of the right to ask. A nation ready to hear its citizens' questions — that is what Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Ratnā never had."

A new hope, a new struggle. "Freedom is not the end of struggle but a new form of it. The roots of caste, gender, poverty do not uproot with the nation's freedom. My work is never complete. But today I feel a new hope whose name I never knew — freedom." That night the village gathers spontaneously to tell every lost name the news: "What you suffered was not in vain."

● *Freedom as a beginning*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Independence placed within the story-cycle, carefully, as a phase not an ending.
- Caste, gender, and poverty injustice do not end automatically with national freedom.
- No single victory, however historic, is the end of the whole tale.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -54

The End of Zamindari

जमींदारीक अन्त *Zamīndārik Ant*

"The land's owner changed, the soil did not — the field knows the name of the one who ploughs it."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Land reform closes the land-justice arc begun with Sukhdev (-92)

Sukhdev's requital, made permanent

The End of Zamindari · जमींदारीक अन्त — card 1 of 1

The law. The new government abolishes zamindari — the centuries-old system under whose shadow the tales from Ugrasen to Raghubīr Singh unfolded. The last zamindar family (Pratāpsen's descendants) surrenders most of its land, much of it distributed to landless and Camār-quarter families. Sukhdev's land, once seized by Ugrasen, returns to his descendants with permanent legal rights.

Just, if not universally welcome. Būrbhā: "Today Sukhdev's requital takes legal, permanent form — to see injustice, however old, corrected given enough generations, patience, and struggle, is the meaning of my whole existence." But Pratāpsen's descendants grow bitter; old land-based bonds strain. "The question is not whether change makes everyone happy, but whether it is just."

Roots, through change. The new generation, schooled, seeks work beyond land — jobs, business, the city. "The village has always changed; no moment was ever unchangeable. My work is not to stop change, but to remember the name and the cost tied to every change — so the village, however it changes, never wholly forgets its roots."

● Land reform

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Zamindari abolition — uneven and incomplete, which the chapter does not hide.
- It permanently affected land-relations and caste-based power in rural India.
- The final, legal culmination of the land-justice arc from -92 and -64.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -53

The First Electric Lamp

बिजलीक पहिल दीप *Bijlik Pahil Dīp*

"The electric lamp is lit, but don't forget the old lamp's oil — let new light come, but not erase the old name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Nehru-era development reaches the village — road, electricity, and new hope

New light, old wick

The First Electric Lamp • बिजलीक पहिल दीप — card 1 of 1

The wires arrive. Under the Five-Year Plan, a paved road and electric wires reach Gaṛh Nārikel for the first time. When the square's first bulb suddenly lights, the whole village freezes — its yellow glow quivering on the pond, on faces, on the coconut leaves. Some fold hands, some lift children to see, some quietly clutch the old clay lamp they have kept for years.

No light feels old. Harivaṃśa — of the generation holding the old cord in one hand and the new age in the other — asks if the electric light makes Būṛhbā's conch-lamp feel old. "No form of light feels old to me. What has not changed is bringing light into darkness, be it lamp or electricity."

Light that shows the name. "But as much light as a lamp gives, it casts that much shadow. If in this new light people forget their old names and faces, it is more dangerous than darkness. Good light is that which shows the name, not that which dazzles it away." Harivaṃśa keeps the old clay lamp in his bag, its oil never fully dry — for relighting a dried wick takes long.

● Modernization without erasure

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Development arrives — and with it the question of what it dazzles away.
- Progress is welcome; forgetting the old name in its glare is the danger.
- Keep the old lamp's oil from drying, even as the new light comes.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -52

The Border's Call

सीमाक पुकार *Sīmāk Pukār*

"Cannon sounded at the border, the sohar sounded in the village — a village that bore war did not let go of the name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The 1962 and 1965 wars call the village youth to the border

A name knows no border

The Border's Call • सीमाक पुकार — card 1 of 1

The youth depart. War-drums sound at distant borders — first from China, then Pakistan — reaching the village by radio and market talk. Youths whose hands were on plough and net now don uniform. Rāmāśray's grandson Vijaykumār joins the army; on his departure night his mother cannot hold back the farewell-lament that rises on its own from the throat.

The waiting courtyard. A deep silence settles in any house that sent a son — neither full fear nor full pride, only waiting. The night-assembly remembers those youths' names separately, and Būṛhbā keeps each name as if it stood, an invisible sentinel, on the distant front. In 1965 Vijaykumār is wounded and returns with a weakened arm.

The body falls, the name returns. "Those who didn't return, their names I hold with equal honour — on some Himalayan peak, some desert. A name knows no border: the body falls where the war is, but the name returns where there are people to remember it." Vijaykumār tells the children his border-tales, always ending with the name of the comrade who could not return — kept alive on the village's tongue.

● *The name outlasts the body*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The 1962 and 1965 wars enter the village through its sons.
- Būṛhbā holds every border-going name, returned or not, with equal honour.
- The crocodile can take the body, not the name — proved again, far from home.



The Seed of the Green Revolution

हरित क्रान्तिक बीया *Harit Krāntik Bīyā*

"New seed yields more, but old seed knows the soil — a seed that saves the village sows not hunger, but the name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- New seeds and chemical fertilizer transform the village's farming

Progress, and the seed kept back

The Seed of the Green Revolution • हरित क्रांतिक बीया — card 1 of 1

The heavy harvest. High-yield seeds and sacks of chemical fertilizer arrive; for the first time the rice-ears grow so heavy the stalks bend, and farmers' eyes gladden at the grain-heaps. But in that yield's shadow, Ratnā's descendants' knowledge quietly fades — which seed suits which soil, which rains, which herb stops which disease.

A seed is memory. Sunaynā asks if losing the old seed is good. Būṛhbā: "More grain is good, protection from hunger is good. But if the old seed is fully lost, you lose a future option. A seed is not just grain — in it sleeps the village's memory of which ancestor faced which famine. Keep the old seed for the day the new seed betrays."

The clay pot in the grove. Sunaynā recalls a lost rice variety that yielded less but would not rot even submerged room-deep in flood. With Ratnā's line she begins keeping the old seeds in a clay pot in a quiet corner of the Channā grove, planting a strip of old rice beside each new field — so the old root lives too, and any famine finds the village holding the seed that once saved its ancestors.

● *To progress without destroying*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The Green Revolution's real gain — and its quiet cost in lost heritage.
- "To progress without destroying knowledge is the real challenge."
- A village that saves its seed saves its future.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -50

The Darkness of the Emergency

आपातकालक अन्हार *Āpātkālak Anhār*

"A dark era does not last — but a lamp put out takes long to relight."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The 1975 Emergency casts a shadow over the assembly's freedom

Tending the inner light

The Darkness of the Emergency • आपातकालक अन्हार — card 1 of 1

The order. When the national Emergency of 1975 is declared, its shadow reaches the village square. Administrative eyes turn on the women's night-assembly; the police-station orders that no gathering meet without permission. The assembly that for years discussed justice by lamplight beside the Channā grove falls under suspicion.

Būṛhbā's counsel. "Your assembly is one of justice, not politics. Keep it going, secretly, carefully. A dark era is not permanent, but the light put out in it can take a long time to relight. When the outer light is dimmed, tend the inner light more carefully — a voice can be suppressed, but not the justice behind it. An assembly once fully closed takes a whole generation to reawaken."

Whispered justice. For two years the assembly runs in the grove's dense dark — no lamp, no voice, only whispers; women come one by one, completing the night's justice-talk by eye-signals and murmurs. No paper written, yet no name dropped — all kept in the village's mind. When the Emergency ends and the lamp is lit openly again, it is said the flame burned higher than before.

● Civil courage in a hard time

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- When public voice is suppressed, the inner light must be tended more carefully.
- A gathering kept barely alive survives; one fully closed takes a generation to revive.
- Dark eras are not permanent — the tended light returns.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -49

The Year of Drought

सूखाक बरख *Sūkhāk Barakh*

"A dry year dries the pond, not the name — a village that digs a well together finds water again."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A Bihar drought tests the village again — now knowledge and outside aid both work

The state and the village, together

The Year of Drought • सूखाक बरख — card 1 of 1

The empty sky. The monsoon fails again; the pond shrinks to mud, the fields crack with thirst. The village has seen this before — Ratnā's-era famine, Hulāsā's-era hunger, still alive in memory — but this time it has learned. Both the government relief system and the village's own organization activate in time.

No name dropped. Sunaynā's son Gopāl, the young pradhān, runs relief-distribution with the officials, keeping account of each household — who got grain, who was missed, who needs more — so relief reaches those who truly need it and no name is lost in the crowd. Būṛhbā: "The state and society working together — this is progress. A famine is also a test of memory: a village that forgets its old famines dies anew in each one."

Water by their own hand. Gopāl and the youth re-dig the old southern well, closed for years; when the first water shows from the depths, the light on the thirsty faces is worth no less than grain. Relief came from outside, but the village found water by its own hand. Gopāl records each household in his notebook, extending Yādavānand's shadow-panjī — this famine too preserved with its every name.

● Memory as preparedness

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- This time both accumulated knowledge and outside help work in time.
- A village keeping account of every famine stands ready for the next.
- Relief from outside, water by one's own hand — both.



The Voice of Radio and Television

रेडियो आ टेलीविजनक अवाज *Reḍiyo ā Ṭelivijanak Avāj*

"The machine's voice comes from afar, the village's song from within — one who hears the inner voice is not lost in the outer noise."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The first radio, then television, bring the world into the village courtyard

The inner voice amid the outer noise

The Voice of Radio and Television • रेडियो आ टेलीविजनक अवाज — card 1 of 1

The world arrives. The square's first radio brings Delhi's crackling voice into the courtyard; a year later the first television gathers children and elders before its quivering black-and-white picture. For the first time the world comes into the village. But with it comes a silence — children who came to the pīpal for tales now sit before the screen, and the women's embankment-songs fade under the new, loud sound.

Two kinds of voice. Kusum asks if this makes Būṛhbā's work easier. "The reverse is also true — the village's tale and name can be lost in the world's noise. There are two voices: one that comes from outside and fills the ear, one that rises from within and fills the mind. If the outer grows so loud the inner can't be heard, the village forgets its song — and forgets its name."

A new stage. When a distant flood appears on the television, the elders fall silent — it recalls their own old flood; the machine can bring the far near, but can also make the near far. Kusum does not turn it off — she makes it a new stage, telling the village's old tales in new form to the children before the screen, so new light and old memory burn together in one courtyard.

● *Media without losing the self*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Mass media brings the world in — and can drown the village's own voice.
- The task: protect the inner voice amid the new, loud noise.
- Kusum's answer — not rejecting the medium, but making it a stage for the old tales.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -47

The Gulf Market

खाड़ी देशक बजार *Khārī Deśak Bajār*

"The foreign market gives wealth, the home hearth gives a name — one who earns and forgets the name returns a stranger."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The Gulf labour boom turns the village youth toward abroad again

A new call of the foreign land

The Gulf Market • खाड़ी देशक बजार — card 1 of 1

The oil boom. In the 1980s the Gulf oil boom draws village youth to Dubai, Kuwait, and Saudi Arabia for construction work. Brokers come to the market, passport-and-visa talk fills the homes, and every few months a young son takes his tin trunk and leaves — a new chapter of the "call of the foreign land," different from Yaśpati's indenture yet essentially related.

Wealth from afar. Kusum's husband Rameś goes to Dubai on a three-year contract — but unlike Rāmsevak's era, he sends letters and money, and sometimes his voice reaches home by phone. Concrete roofs, dowered weddings, new goods come on that far-off money — yet many courtyards lie silent all year without their young sons.

Keep the name at home. Būṛhbā: "Distance remains, but communication is now possible — this is progress, though the sorrow of distance is as true. Abroad keeps the body in a market; if a person is not careful, he keeps his name there too. Rameś sends money — good; he keeps his name in the village — better." Kusum sets a new token at the pond-root — a lamp of waiting, so the call becomes a symbol of hope, not only grief.

● Migration and the name

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The Gulf migration — a new form of the old "pardeśak pukār" (cf. -67).
- Communication softens distance, but the sorrow of the empty courtyard remains.
- One who forgets village, language, and name for wealth returns a stranger.



The Test of Harmony

सद्भावक परीक्षा *Sadbhāvak Parīkṣā*

"When the fire came, the village became one — harmony is tested not in festivals, but in calamity."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A wave of communal tension tests the village's pluralist tradition

Shared memory against imported division

The Test of Harmony • सद्भावक परीक्षा — card 1 of 1

The rumor. In the late 1980s a wave of communal tension rises in the region and reaches Gaṛh Nārikel as rumor. Outsiders try to turn the old Hindu-Muslim brotherhood into suspicion; whispers spread, and for a night or two an unfamiliar tension pervades the square.

Woven together for generations. But the village's Muslim families — whose ancestors drew from the same pond, worked the same fields, saved each other in the same floods — and its Hindu families stand together. An old maulvi and an old pandit stand at the square, reminding the village which house rescued whom in which flood, whose hearth fed whom in which famine. Before that shared memory, the imported rumor cannot stand.

Remember each other's names. Būṛhbā: "Your village has woven nyāya, tantra, bhakti together for centuries — this unity is your greatest strength. Division comes from outside, not within; it takes root only where people have forgotten each other. Remember each other's names — that is the greatest watch." From that night, Eid and Diwali alike are kept in the pīpal's shade, in both communities' presence.

● Pluralism as strength

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Lived interdependence and shared history resist externally-imported division.
- A village that knows each other's names cannot be made strangers by rumor.
- Harmony is tested not in festivals but in calamity — and here it held.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -45

The Wind of Liberalization

उदारीकरणक हवा *Udārīkaraṇak Havā*

"The new wind opened the door, but did not shake the root — a village joined to its root does not fly off in the wind."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The 1991 economic reforms bring new consumerism and new opportunity

Deepen the root against the fast wind

The Wind of Liberalization • उदारीकरणक हवा — card 1 of 1

New goods, new haste. After the 1991 reforms the market's face changes — colorful plastic, new cloth, the first cable television with dozens of channels. Things once out of reach come near, and desires grow with the market. Kusum's son Dines gets a city private-company job, once impossible; there is glamour in the new speed, but under it he misses the village's calm dusk.

The thinning square. New glamour brings new haste — people want more, run more; the pīpal's calm dusk, where the whole village once gathered, thins. Some youth leave for the city; some thresholds stay closed all year. Dines: "Market, television, jobs — all new."

Welcome the new, root deeper. Būṛhbā: "The village has always changed, but this change is fast, and in fast change the risk of losing slowly-learned lessons is greater. The wind opens the door — good; but if the root is weak, that same wind can uproot the tree. Welcome new things, but deepen your root — one who is rooted does not fly off in any wind." Dines takes his children to the pīpal, telling them the tales of tree, pond, and names.

● Openness with rootedness

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Liberalization opens the door to new light — and new haste.
- Fast change risks losing slowly-learned wisdom.
- Welcome the new, but deepen the root — the rooted are not blown away.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -44

The First Computer

पहिल कम्प्यूटर *Pahil Kampyutar*

"The new machine teaches counting, not names — a name the village keeps is bigger than the machine's number."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The first computer reaches the school — the seed of a digital archive

The medium changes; the soul must not

The First Computer • पहिल कम्प्यूटर — card 1 of 1

The grey machine. Under a government scheme, the first computer reaches the Nārikel-pāt Pāṭhaśālā — green letters flickering on a screen. Letters that took years to write by hand now appear in an instant. An old man whispers: "The machine can hold letters, but will it hold meaning?"

From coconut leaf to screen. Pratimā types the first line of the village's oldest folk-song; as it glows on screen she feels the old song stepping toward an unfamiliar home. Būṛhbā: "The medium keeps changing — paper, press, now this machine. But the story's soul — the village's language and viewpoint — must not change. If it keeps my story in my own words, I welcome it."

The newest sentinel. "The machine knows counting — letters, pages, years. But a name is bigger than counting. If it turns a name into mere number, it is more dangerous than the coconut leaf; if it keeps the name with its full meaning, it can become the village's newest sentinel." The students begin typing old songs — a small bridge that, years ahead, becomes a full digital archive in the village's own language.

● Digitizing without hollowing

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The medium evolves — coconut leaf, press, computer — the soul stays.
- A machine that keeps names as meaning, not mere number, guards the village.
- The small bridge from leaf to screen foreshadows a full digital archive.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -43

The Drying River

सुखल होइत धार *Sukhal Hoit Dhār*

"The river thinned, yet knows the old path — a dried river has not forgotten the flood."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The Kamalā-Balān falls — the village faces an age of environmental crisis

A new crocodile — of water, air, and soil

The Drying River • सुखल होइत धार — card 1 of 1

The falling river. The Kamalā-Balān's water-level falls year by year; the river that once touched both embankments now shows sandbars in summer. Forests are cut, distant factory pollution reaches the water, fish grow fewer. Water, once the village's greatest fear, becomes its greatest worry.

Not lack of offering. Satyanārāyaṇ: "The twin pond has shrunk. I fear nature itself is falling sick." Būṛhbā: "Sonmā said the Mūl Gohi needs patience and offering. But this crisis is not from lack of offering — it is nature's own injustice. You must plant trees and save water, just as you save names."

Save water like a name. "I taught you to save names, thinking the crocodile takes only the body. But a new crocodile has come — one drinking the water, dirtying the air, eating the soil. If you don't save water, forest and soil, one day the very village that keeps names won't survive." Satyanārāyaṇ plants trees around the grove, embanks the pond, digs check-dams, and starts planting a tree at each birth.

● The environmental crocodile

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Falling water tables, deforestation, and pollution as a slow new calamity.
- This crisis is nature's own injustice, not a lack of offering.
- Now, alongside names, save water, forest, and soil for the next generation.



The Miracle of the Handheld Phone

हाथक फोनक चमत्कार *Hāthak Phonak Camatkār*

"A machine in the hand made the far near — but don't forget to ask the name of the one sitting near."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The mobile phone completely changes village communication

The far comes near, the near must not go far

The Miracle of the Handheld Phone • हाथक फोनक चमत्कार — card 1 of 1

The little machine speaks. The first mobile phone reaches the village in the headman's hand; when a far-off city son's voice emerges, the whole courtyard gathers astonished — a voice that once took a month of waiting now reaches the ear in an instant. Soon phones reach many families: sons abroad talk instantly, and every news arrives in a moment.

The new blindness. But a new sight appears — people talking to someone far while forgetting someone sitting beside them. Añjali: "Now the call of the foreign land won't be so sad." Būṛhbā, smiling: "Good news. But as much as this machine connects, it can confuse. In it, someone far comes near — be careful someone near doesn't become far. One always immersed in far-off voices forgets to look at the parent beside them."

Old affection, new machine. An old woman, hearing her Gulf-son's voice, weeps: "It feels you're standing in the courtyard." Used rightly, the machine lightens the sorrow of distance; misused, it makes near people strangers. Añjali teaches the elders to use it — yet keeps saying the evening square, sitting face to face, can never be replaced, so the new machine runs with old affection and old caution.

● Connection and its illusion

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The mobile phone dissolves distance — and can dissolve nearness too.
- If it brings the name near, good; if it makes the near name far, it is the greatest illusion.
- Añjali's answer — the machine alongside the face-to-face square, not replacing it.



The City Market

शहरक बजार *Śaharak Bajār*

"The city buys the body, the village does not sell the name — one who sold his name in the market returns empty-handed."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The IT boom draws the village's educated youth to the big cities

Go far from the root without cutting it

The City Market • शहरक बजार — card 1 of 1

The new flight. India's IT boom draws the village's educated youth to Bangalore, Hyderabad, and Delhi for software and other modern jobs. Children who once learned letters on the coconut leaf now learn the computer's language and earn good salaries in far cities. Every household is proud — but their festivals pass in the city, and many houses stay locked all year.

The ache of distance. Añjali's son Karuṇākar, back on holiday: "In the city I learned much, but sometimes I feel I'm cutting away from my roots." Būṛhbā: "Cutting the root and going far from it are two different things. However far you go, if once a year you come to the pīpal and remember your name and the village's tale, the root won't cut — it will only lengthen."

Rooted, a stranger nowhere. "As far as a tree's root spreads, that firmly it stands. Going far is not weakness; weakness is forgetting the root. Roam the world — but remember your name, your language. One who knows his root is a stranger nowhere." From that day, every returning youth keeps an unwritten tradition: however far you go, once a year, return to your root for an evening.

● Mobility with belonging

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The IT boom carries the schooled youth outward — with pride and with distance.
- Going far is not cutting the root; forgetting it is.
- One evening a year at the root keeps the far-flung a stranger nowhere.



The Right to Information

सूचनाक अधिकार *Sūcanāk Adhikār*

"One who has the right to know can ask — information is a lamp that shows the name in the dark."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The RTI Act lets the village demand its own records — the shadow made light

Shadow and light become one

The Right to Information • सूचनाक अधिकार — card 1 of 1

The law. The Right to Information Act gives ordinary citizens the right to demand their papers from government offices. For Garh Nārikel this is no ordinary news — for centuries it had preserved its history secretly as Yādavānand's shadow-panjī, and now that history could be openly demanded by legal right.

Proving each other. The youth demand the village's land and history papers from the archives; records once locked in officials' cabinets come into the village's hands. Vibhā finds the yellow, torn papers hold many names also in Yādavānand's panjī — each proving the other. Truth once kept only in village memory now stands legally, with a government seal.

The day awaited for centuries. Būṛhbā, deeply satisfied: "This is the day I've waited centuries for — when shadow and light become one, when secretly-kept truth can be openly demanded. Yādavānand wrote by night's lamp because openly speaking truth was dangerous then. Now the law says every citizen has the right to know his truth." Vibhā merges shadow-panjī and state records into a complete, legally-valid history no official can erase.

● The secret history, legalized

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- RTI turns the counter-canon from a secret survival into an official right.
- Village memory and state record, placed face to face, prove one another.
- The names saved so long in shadow can now stand openly in light.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -39

The Guarantee of Work

काजक गारंटी *Kājak Gāraṇṭī*

"One who has work stands with his hand raised — work gives a name, not alms."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The employment-guarantee scheme gives local work — and the watch it needs

A good law needs a constant watch

The Guarantee of Work • काजक गारंटी — card 1 of 1

Work at home. The rural employment-guarantee scheme gives every family a hundred guaranteed days of work in the village itself. Labourers who once fled to the city — whose forefathers suffered abroad and indenture like Rāmsevak and Bhola — now work on their own soil; families that once broke apart can stay together.

The seed and the tree. Sureś, the local coordinator: "This won't repeat the tale of Bhola, Sukhdev, and Rāmsevak." Būṛhbā: "However good on paper, a scheme's success depends on honest implementation. Bhola's court-tale taught me law and practice can be far apart. A law is a good seed; but a seed doesn't become a tree by itself — it needs honest hands and steady water."

Every name, every account. "If the money is lost midway, if a labourer's name is dropped from the attendance, this good law too can become a new injustice." When some wages got stuck, Sureś read every name and account openly before the village and demanded the dues until every hand got them. He keeps every account transparent — the real watch of the scheme.

● Implementation is everything

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Local guaranteed work ends the old compulsion to migrate for a livelihood.
- A good law is only a seed; honest hands make it a tree.
- Keeping every name and account clean is the scheme's real watch.



The Web of the Internet

इंटरनेटक जाल *Inṭarneṭak Jāl*

"The new web brings the far near, but turns the name into a number — one caught in it loses his own face."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Smartphones and the internet transform the village — for good and ill

Gaṅgeśa's four proofs, made a daily necessity

The Web of the Internet • इंटरनेटक जाल — card 1 of 1

The world in the palm. Smartphones and cheap internet reach the village; children who learned on the coconut leaf now hold the whole world in their palm. But with the new web come false news spreading like truth, discontent bred by others' glittering lives, and unknown people making unwanted contact with the young.

A new śaṅkha-rajata. Nīraj: "The internet holds much that can deceive us." Būṛhbā: "With every new power comes a new danger — from the śaṅkha-rajata illusion to today, this is the lesson of my whole tale. This web can become a new śaṅkha-rajata, where falsehood glitters like truth."

Ask, and you are not caught. "Gaṅgeśa taught the four means of proof — perception, inference, comparison, testimony. That was scripture then; today it is a necessity of life. Whatever you see, ask: where did it come from? who said it? what is the proof?" Nīraj forms a group that traces a viral falsehood to its root and disproves it — learning, like Gaṅgeśa's four proofs, to separate truth from illusion.

● Epistemology as survival

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The internet is a new śaṅkha-rajata — falsehood that glitters like truth (cf. –100, –97).
- Gaṅgeśa's four pramāṇas become a daily test, not just scripture.
- Only a questioning eye tells truth from illusion in the new web.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -37

The First Shadow of the Screen

स्क्रीनक पहिल छाया *Skrīnak Pahil Chāyā*

"A face shines on the screen, the name dark behind it — one who hides to frighten is weak in the light."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Social media brings a new kind of ghost — hidden behind the screen's light

The ghost of darkness cannot stand in light

The First Shadow of the Screen • स्क्रीनक पहिल छाया — card 1 of 1

The screen's shadow. Facebook and WhatsApp reach every hand — distant relatives near, old friends met again. But the screen that connects also brings rumor, fraud, and online harassment. The ghost that once dwelt in the Channā grove's darkness now dwells behind the screen's light, hiding name and face.

Speak, and stand together. Sapnā: an unknown person is threatening a village girl with her photo. Būṛhbā, voice trembling: "A power that works in darkness by frightening someone grows weak in the light. This ghost's greatest power is its silence — it wants the victim silent and alone. Its greatest answer is to speak, to stand together. What is spoken openly, its shame shifts from the victim onto the swindler."

The digital night-assembly. At the first digital night-assembly the threatened girl speaks openly; when twenty women stand with her, the hidden hand's threat grows weak, and her smile returns. Sapnā gives the old women's night-assembly a new form — a "digital night-assembly" where online harassment is shared and confronted, so fear grown in darkness weakens in the light, together.

● *Breaking the silence*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Online abuse's power is the victim's isolation and shame.
- Spoken openly, the shame shifts from victim to perpetrator.
- The women's night-assembly (-66) reborn for the digital age.



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Chapter -36

The First Footfall of the Unseen Swindler

अनदेखल ठगक पहिल आहट *Andekhal Thagak Pahil Āhaṭ*

"The swindler you cannot see is the greatest — hear the footfall, ask the name, trust the eye, not the paper."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A serious digital fraud shakes the village — a new, faceless hunger

A crocodile with no body, no water

The First Footfall of the Unseen Swindler • अनदेखल ठगक पहिल आहट — card 1 of 1

The vanishing company. A village youth, lured by a job scam, loses his entire savings to a fake online company — website, office photos, an officer's voice, all of which vanish in one night. The scam is run from a distant land by an unseen hand; a police report is filed, but how do you catch what you cannot even see? The village faces an enemy with no face, no address.

A new kind of crocodile. Sapnā: "This is more terrible than the Mūl Gohi — that one I could see and make offerings to; this one I cannot even see." Būṛhbā, long silent: "You are right. This is a new crocodile — no body, no water, only a hunger dwelling within wires and screens. I don't know how my old knowledge will fight it. But the name it eats, I too will hold."

Awareness is the only defence. "The old crocodile I fought with offering, patience, name. This one asks no offering — it swindles trust. There is only one way to defeat it: awareness. A village that stays alert, warns each other, and doesn't blindly trust any glittering offer keeps this new crocodile hungry." Sapnā warns every family — knowing the coming tale will be far more complex and dangerous.

● *The faceless hunger*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Digital fraud — a crocodile with no body, no water, no address.
- It asks no offering; it swindles trust — and awareness is the only defence.
- This footfall seeds the contemporary crime strands the novel will pursue.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -35

The Market of Bodies Opens

देहक बजार खुजैत अछि *Dehak Bajār Khujait Achi*

"Where the body is sold, the name is cheap — but a village that keeps the name won't let the body become a market."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The job scam becomes human trafficking — the darkest chapter's footfall

The question is the only weapon

The Market of Bodies Opens • देहक बजार खुजैत अछि — card 1 of 1

From money to people. The job-scam takes a more terrible form: earlier the swindler took only money; now he takes people. Youth lured by promises of "good work" abroad are taken by brokers to distant lands, their passports seized, forced to work — the tale reaching the village piece by piece. In one house, a son who left on a "good work" promise vanishes for years; his mother's eyes stay on the road every evening.

The dark chapter's footfall. Rājiv: "This is more terrible than indenture — there was at least a contract, a date. Now people become captives." Būṛhbā, grave: "This is the dark chapter whose footfall I heard long ago. The hunger that dwelt within the screen has reached the market of bodies. We must warn every family, as we warned of flood, fire, and disease."

A new school. "The weapon to defeat this crocodile is not the sword, but the question. Where a promise seems too good, too quick, ask — who is calling? which company? which paper? who guarantees it?" Rājiv teaches every youth to scrutinize foreign job offers — a new school, not on the coconut leaf but as necessary, to save the village's children from the market's dark hand.

● Awareness as protection

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The scam escalates from stealing money to trafficking people.
- Verification — who, which company, which paper, who guarantees — is the defence.
- Saving names is now not only memory's work, but life's work.



The Vision of Ujjwal

उज्ज्वलक स्वप्न *Ujjwalak Svapna*

"The dream is large, but the root is in the soil — a dream that forgets the name wakes alone."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The figure of a vision Būṛhbā had long ago is born in reality — Ujjwal Jhā

A name held from the first night

The Vision of Ujjwal • उज्ज्वलक स्वप्न — card 1 of 1

The restless witness. A child is born in a poor village family — sohar sung, jaggery shared, the child named Ujjwal Jhā. But on the birth-night Būṛhbā, always glad at a new birth, grows strangely restless, as if an old memory has come alive; a deep worry sits in his eyes as he keeps looking toward that poor house.

The vision recalled. Dīpālī asks why. Būṛhbā: "Long ago, in a flash, I saw a youth who would drown not in the river but in the screen — under lost money, interest, threats. Today that child is born. His name is Ujjwal Jhā. I don't know if I can save him, but I hold his name from today."

Not alone in the dark. "The name I hold from today will not be alone. When that darkness comes before him, the village will know him, remember his name — and perhaps, by that one thing, he will not be alone even in the darkness." The village keeps an unspoken watch on little Ujjwal; Dīpālī marks his name specially in her notebook, knowing its story will matter greatly.

● The protagonist arrives

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Ujjwal Jhā — the central contemporary figure — is born here.
- Būṛhbā's long-ago vision of a "drowning in the screen" takes a name.
- A name held early means one is never wholly alone in the dark to come.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -33

The Shadow of the Lawyer's Coat

वकीलक कोटक छाया *Vakīlak Koṭak Chāyā*

"In the court's shadow justice hides, in the village it speaks — the lawyer reads the statute, the village reads the name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A village youth studies law — and his path turns toward the "court's ghost"

No one is born guilty

The Shadow of the Lawyer's Coat • वकीलक कोटक छाया — card 1 of 1

The bright boy. Baṭuknāth, once sharpest at the coconut-leaf school, studies law and practices in the city. The village is proud, hoping he'll fight for the poor — and at first he does, taking the weak's side. But with powerful clients, the taste of winning, the glitter of money, and the intoxication of power turn him, step by step, off his path: the law he studied to save the poor, he learns to twist to save the powerful.

The seed of -68 flowers. Dīpālī: "He takes date after date in every case, however poor the other side — he behaves like the court's ghost." Būṛhbā, sadly: "The seed sown in chapter -68 now flowers in a human body. He was not born guilty — the system's slowness, temptation, and the taste of power turned him. I'll hold his name in hope that he changes his path again."

Held with hope, not a curse. "The seed falls in one place, the flower blooms in another. He is the fruit of a system that made justice a thing to be sold. I hold his name not with a curse but with hope — for one who can change his path, his name is never wholly killed." When a poor village widow stands before him, the old village flashes in his eyes for a moment — the honest Baṭuknāth not fully dead, only hidden in the dark.

● *A fallen figure, held in hope*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The "court's ghost" seed (-68) flowers into a living antagonist.
- No one is born guilty — a corrupt system shapes the corrupt person.
- His name is held with hope, not a curse — the path can still be changed.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -32

The Shadow from Across the Sea

समुद्रपारक साये *Samudrapārak Sāye*

"A shadow can come from across seven seas, but cannot carry the name away — one who cheats from afar still leaves a mark on the leaf."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An unseen power in a Hong Kong glass-tower appears on the horizon — Lau Kin-hang

The crocodile changes water, remains the crocodile

The Shadow from Across the Sea • समुद्रपारक साये — card 1 of 1

The wire crosses the sea. Through global trade and digital finance, the village's scam-tales now reach across the sea. Money swindled from a poor hand passes, wire by wire, across countries into an unseen hand. Abhinav reads a report with a photo of a tall glass tower in a distant city, and a recurring name that plants an unfamiliar dread.

A name heard long ago. "The paper says many scam-nets are run from Hong Kong — one name keeps recurring, Lau Kin-hang." Būṛhbā, in a voice never heard before: "I too heard this name long ago, in a flash — a shadow in a glass tower. I don't know his relation to my Ujjwal and my Baṭuknāth. But all these tales, even from far, will one day return to Gaṛh Nārikel."

The same rule. "The crocodile changes water but remains the crocodile — first the pond, then the screen, now across the sea in a glass tower. The rule holds: it can take the body, not the name. If the village keeps its name and warns each other, this distant shadow too will weaken before the village's light." The shadow on the newspaper page will one day stand, directly, in the village's own tale.

● *The trans-national antagonist*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Lau Kin-hang — the glass-tower shadow — enters the story's horizon.
- Digital fraud is global: the same hunger, now across the sea.
- The old rule still holds — it takes the body, not the name.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -31

Satyavrat's Silence

सत्यव्रतक मौन *Satyavratak Maun*

"One long silent, his single word is heaviest — Satyavrat's silence, too, was a testimony."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A silent bank clerk sways between duty and conscience — and starts a notebook

When silence becomes injustice

Satyavrat's Silence • सत्यव्रतक मौन — card 1 of 1

The suspicious accounts. Satyavrat Mehta — quiet, honest, who speaks little but sees everything — gets a city bank job. He begins seeing suspicious accounts: lakhs arriving, instantly splitting into other accounts and vanishing. He understands it is a thread of some large hidden net — but he is only a small clerk. Who would listen, and what danger in speaking?

The moment to speak. Būṛhbā: "Silence is sometimes protection, sometimes injustice. I can't decide for you — that's your conscience. Staying silent when the moment hasn't come is patience; but if the moment has come and one stays silent, that silence becomes injustice. Recognizing that moment is conscience. And if it comes, have proof, not just words — what you see, write down."

The waiting testimony. Satyavrat neither speaks nor stays wholly silent — he quietly records in his notebook the date and detail of each suspicious transaction, waiting for the moment when this silence could become testimony. He does not yet know how important this notebook will one day become.

● The whistleblower's discipline

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Silence can be patience or injustice — the conscience must tell the moment.
- When the moment comes, evidence matters more than words: write what you see.
- The quiet notebook becomes a testimony held in waiting.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -30

Gop Kumar's Document

गोप कुमारक दस्तावेज *Gop Kumārak Dastāvej*

"What is kept in writing outlasts time — a document saves not the body, but the name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A youth devotes his life to the record — the witness, perhaps author, of the final chapter

A bridge across the centuries

Gop Kumar's Document • गोप कुमारक दस्तावेज — card 1 of 1

Joining the threads. Gop Kumar, extending Yādavānand's and Vibhā's tradition, gives his life to documentation — joining old maps, old panjī, and new digital records, thread by thread. The names Yādavānand wrote in night's darkness, the papers Vibhā brought by RTI, the records now made on screen — all matched together. People say: "this youth wants to make the village's memory immortal."

Not yet complete. "Has the time come to compile your whole tale?" Būṛhbā: "Haripati asked me this, and I said — not until the tale is complete. One final chapter remains, whose footfall I've heard year by year. It will be the hardest — in it will be Ujjwal, Baṭuknāth, that distant shadow. When they all come to one place, then you will write."

Witness, not decoration. "Compiling the tale is not decoration, it is being a witness — one who writes must bear its every joy, sorrow, and injustice within." Finding a flood-lost name beside Yādavānand's note, Gop Kumar realizes he is building a bridge across centuries, on which every lost name could return — and keeps every thread for the day the whole tale stands in one hand.

● The witness-author

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Gop Kumar — the in-story archivist who may write the whole tale.
- The compilation is itself an act of witness, not mere arrangement.
- The final chapter — Ujjwal, Baṭuknāth, the glass-tower shadow — is still to come.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -29

Chandrapāl's Dream

चन्द्रपालक सपना *Chandrapālak Sapnā*

"A dream in the eye, a deception at the foot — one who signed without understanding was caught in the net."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A youth born far from the village — and Būṛhbā's watch crosses the boundary

The watch that leaves the village bounds

Chandrapāl's Dream • चन्द्रपालक सपना — card 1 of 1

A distant birth. In a distant relative-family long settled in Meerut — connected to the village now only by an old name and an occasional letter — a child is born: Chandrapāl Batra. Yet on the birth-night Būṛhbā feels a strange restlessness, and the village is puzzled: why be restless for a child born hundreds of miles away in an unknown city?

A wider witness. Būṛhbā: "My witness-sense has grown wider than the village's bounds — like your digital record, Gop Kumar, which now connects even far-flung relations. This child will, in time, become part of my tale, though he may never see the village. I hold his name — Chandrapāl."

The net knows no boundary. "The new crocodile, dwelling in wires and screens, knows no village boundary — it can swindle someone in Meerut as easily as in Gaṛh Nārikel. So my watch too must go beyond the village." Gop Kumar adds a new section, "Distant Connections," with Chandrapāl its first entry — realizing the tale is now that of every name that could, anywhere, fall into the new crocodile's net.

● The watch expands

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- As the digital net spreads, Būṛhbā's witness reaches beyond village soil.
- A name that can fall into the net, wherever born, is now held.
- The tale becomes not Gaṛh Nārikel's alone, but every vulnerable name's.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -28

Rāghav's Code

राघवक कोड *Rāghavak Koḍ*

"The language the machine understands, the village does not — but inside the code too a name lies hidden."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A gifted young programmer whose skill could guard thousands — or swindle them

A sword is neither good nor bad

Rāghav's Code • राघवक कोड — card 1 of 1

The prodigy. In a branch of the family, in the town, Rāghav is born with a mind extraordinary for code — grasping in play the logic that takes big engineers years. In his teens he astonishes people, fixing complex machines, catching hidden errors. Wise elders quietly note: such power in good hands can save thousands; in wrong hands, swindle as many.

Būṛhbā's question-mark. "Extraordinary power can go both ways — protection or destruction. A sword is neither good nor bad; the mind of the one who holds it makes it so. Rāghav's skill is a sword. If he remembers his name, village, conscience, it will guard thousands; if he runs only after power, this same skill can become a new crocodile."

An empty space for time to fill. Once, Rāghav fixes a poor family's stuck papers in minutes, and they get their due — his power, well used, could make him the village's greatest guardian. But Būṛhbā's question-mark stays firm beside the name. Gop Kumar writes Rāghav's name with a question-mark — an empty space to be filled by his own future choice, on which much of the village's fate may rest.

● Power awaiting a choice

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Extraordinary skill is a tool that can guard or destroy.
- The wielder's mind — remembering the root — decides which.
- Rāghav's name is held with a question-mark: his choice is still to come.



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Chapter -27

Āruṇi's Construction

आरुणिक निर्माण *Āruṇik Nirmāṇ*

"One who builds must first shape himself — Āruṇi shaped his own eye before the sluice."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- An engineer gives the village's old embankment a modern form

Building is not enough — keeping alive is

Āruṇi's Construction • आरुणिक निर्माण — card 1 of 1

Old knowledge, new form. Āruṇi, an engineer, takes up bridge and embankment work, never forgetting the childhood floods and Indrāṇī's warning-system. He gives the old earthen embankment a new form — brick, and instruments for flood-forecast — but knows it is incomplete without the old knowledge: the elders who read the river's nature, the women who read the water's rise, no less than any machine.

Tended each generation. Būṛhbā: "No construction, however strong, lasts without care, just as my grove weakens without care. An embankment, a village, a memory — all must be tended anew each generation. A bridge strong today can weaken under the next generation's neglect. Not only building, but keeping the built thing alive, is real construction."

Whose victory it was. When a great flood tests Āruṇi's new embankment, the village keeps watch all night with lamps — and it holds. But Āruṇi knows the victory belongs not only to the stone but to the hands that stayed awake: any embankment holds by the labour and care of a village that calls it its own. He adds a long-term care-plan to every project — shaping not only stone, but the future of that stone.

● Maintenance as construction

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Modern engineering joined to the elders' and women's water-knowledge.
- What is built weakens without care in every generation.
- An embankment holds by the labour of a village that owns it.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -26

Devikā's Song

देविकाक गीत *Devikāk Gīt*

"A song in her throat, justice in her voice — the name called in the song echoed through the village."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A young woman devotes her life to carrying the folk-song tradition forward

A name dwells in a song

Devikā's Song · देविकाक गीत — card 1 of 1

Recording the last voices. Devikā, extending Mohan's melody-tradition, records every old folk-song — Hulāsā's, Jīvantī's, Gaṅgeśa's — with new tunes and instruments. Songs that lived only on the embankment, the water-ghat, the threshing-floor now become permanent. She sits with the old women, records their flood-songs, sohars, and dirges exactly, then reshapes them for the new generation.

Saving songs is saving names. Būṛhbā, glad: "You are completing Mohan's dream. A melody, however old, if it lives in a new throat, never dies. Saving names and saving songs are one work — for a name dwells in a song. When Hulāsā's song is sung, Hulāsā, in that moment, lives again."

The last refrain saved. The oldest woman sings a famine-refrain no one else knows; days later she is gone, but her voice and the names within it are safe forever. Devikā opens a music branch of the Nārikel-pāt Pāṭhaśālā, where every child learns an old song before learning letters — so the village's melody, and its names, never break in any generation.

● Cultural memory

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The folk-song tradition (from Mohan, -73) carried to the digital present.
- A name lives in its song — to keep the song is to keep the name.
- The last voices are recorded before they are lost forever.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -25

Mīrā's Privacy

मीराक निजता *Mīrāk Nijatā*

"Whose the story, theirs the consent — a name is no sample; Mīrā's story is Mīrā's own."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A young woman raises her voice for the right to digital privacy

The right to privacy is the right to the name

Mīrā's Privacy • मीराक निजता — card 1 of 1

A crocodile that eats the name. Mīrā, working on digital privacy and women's safety, extends Sapnā's "digital night-assembly" with legal aid — so women who suffer online injustice get concrete help, not only sympathy. She sees new injustices: a woman's photo stolen, her information sold, her name used without consent. The crocodile that ate the body now eats women's privacy, dignity, name.

Heir of Sulochanā and Padmā. Būṛhbā: "You are the modern heir of Sulochanā and Padmā's tale. The right to privacy is, finally, the right to the name — that no one uses your name or image without your consent. This new crocodile wants to eat the name too. Whose the name, theirs the consent — that is the greatest watch."

Into the light. When a young woman's stolen photo is used to defame her, Mīrā, with legal help, brings the hidden hand into the light, and the woman stands again with her head high. The fight for privacy is, finally, the fight for dignity. Mīrā teaches every woman the right to digital security — the fight only begun, but no woman now alone in it.

● Privacy as dignity

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The women's assembly (-66) and digital night-assembly (-37) grow a legal arm.
- Privacy is the right to one's own name and image — consent is the watch.
- The fight for privacy is, at root, the fight for dignity.



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Chapter -24

Niśānt's Bank

निशांतक बैंक *Niśāntak Baīnk*

"Whose account is clean, whose mind is steady — but one who sold the name in the ledger lost in the reckoning."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A young banker takes up financial inclusion, in the people's own language

Sharing knowledge is real inclusion

Nisānt's Bank • निशांतक बैंक — card 1 of 1

The old net's new form. Nisānt takes up rural financial inclusion — a bank account, insurance, and loans for every family. He had heard how the village poor, caught in the moneylender's compound interest, lost field, home, and honour. But he sees the bank's papers and language are as unfamiliar to the illiterate farmer as the moneylender's ledger once was.

Injustice where one side understands. Būṛhbā: "Injustice is born where one side understands and the other doesn't. The moneylender cheated the poor because they didn't understand accounts. If the bank stays as complex, it becomes only the moneylender's new form. But explain every scheme in the farmer's own speech, and he takes his rights into his own hands. Sharing knowledge is real inclusion."

Confidence in one's rights. An old farmer who always feared the thumbprint opens, after Nisānt's simple explanation, his first account; when his first insurance money arrives, tears come to his eyes. The bank's real work is not keeping money but giving the poor confidence in their rights. Nisānt explains every scheme in simple Maithili at the square — and no family is cheated by the bank's complex language again.

● Financial inclusion

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A complex bank, unexplained, becomes only the moneylender's new form.
- Translating the scheme into the people's speech is the real work.
- The bank's true task is confidence in one's rights, not merely keeping money.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT • KEYSTONE

Chapter -23

The Birth of Nand

नन्दक जन्म *Nandak Janma*

"One who is born brings a new name — Nand's birth gave the village a new witness."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The child whose tale, far ahead, becomes the beginning of the novel — Nand Āruṇi

The village's next witness

The Birth of Nand • नन्दक जन्म — card 1 of 1

The still tree. In Āruṇi's home a son is born, named Nand. On the birth-night the pīpal witness-tree is unusually still, as if awaiting this birth; the elders say they have rarely seen such stillness — as if something great were about to happen. Those who know Būṛhbā notice he gives this birth a special, deep attention, as if seeing what no one else can.

A name that carries a whole tale. Būṛhbā, tender: "I hold this child's name with special affection. Some names carry not one life but a whole tale on their shoulders. Nand's is such. He will be witness to the day my whole tale — from śaṅkha and rajata to today — comes to one place and finds its final form. Shape him well; he is the village's next witness."

The last page in a small hand. Āruṇi sits long under the tree, vowing to shape Nand with the eye that sees name and account above body and paper. The pīpal's leaves rustle faintly though the air is still — as if the whole grove welcomes the new name. And Būṛhbā gazes at Nand's tiny hand, as if seeing in it the last page of his tale.

● The novel's beginning is born

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Nand Āruṇi — whose tale opens गोहि सभक बीच जलसमाधि — is born here.
- Some names carry a whole tale, not one life.
- Būṛhbā names him the village's next witness, for the final chapter to come.



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Chapter -22

Near Twelve Hundred

बारह सयक निकट *Bārah Sayak Nikaṭ*

"Twelve hundred years did not pass in one breath — a village that bore so much stands near the end."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Būṛhbā, counting his age, nears a startling round number

A number, and the tale behind it

Near Twelve Hundred • बारह सयक निकट — card 1 of 1

Adding up the centuries. Gop Kumar sits to add Būṛhbā's whole timeline — from Vācaspati Mīśra to today — generation by generation, name by name. Among hundreds of names, one stands firm in every generation: Būṛhbā's. He realizes he is joining not one life's account but a whole civilization's memory. "By my count, your water-burial is now nearly twelve hundred years old!"

Būṛhbā's laugh. Būṛhbā laughs softly — the rare, unforgettable "Būṛhbā's laugh." "I gave up counting my age long ago. But a number is only a mark, not the tale. Twelve hundred years is not what matters; what matters is how many names were saved, how many lost, how many are still held."

Humanity's will to survive. In that number are many floods, famines, wars, epidemics — and in each the village broke, rose, broke, rose again. Gop Kumar feels this is not one village's tale but humanity's own will to survive. He marks the calculation specially, not knowing this round number would one day, in another language, become like the title of the whole tale, written again.

● The twelve-hundred-year witness

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The "twelve hundred years" folk-time (from the keystone -90) is confirmed.
- The number is only a mark; the tale is the names saved, lost, and still held.
- A village that rose after every death embodies humanity's will to survive.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -21

Ananyā's Question

अनन्याक प्रश्न *Ananyāk Praśna*

"A small question cracks a great dome — one who asked saved the name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- A young teacher teaches the children to question — Gaṅgeśa's method, reborn

The weapon Nand will need

Ananyā's Question • अनन्याक प्रश्न — card 1 of 1

Praise for the question. Ananyā comes to teach at the school's modern branch — teaching children not to memorize answers but to ask questions. In her class no question is foolish; the child who asks the most is praised the most. The rote-schooled elders are surprised, then see her children accept nothing blindly — they ask, test, reason. And Nand asks the most, as if an old curiosity has come alive in him.

Gaṅgeśa in simple speech. Ananyā: "I want to teach Gaṅgeśa's epistemology — perception, inference, testimony, comparison — in simple language." Būṛhbā, deeply satisfied: "My greatest hope is that Gaṅgeśa's question never falls silent, but rises again from every generation's child. A village that stops asking is the first to be cheated. You are shaping the village's next watch."

The conch and the question. When Ananyā tells the śaṅkha-rajata tale, Nand alone raises his hand: "If that man had asked whether it was really silver, he wouldn't have been cheated?" — and in that small question she sees the whole knowledge Gaṅgeśa taught. The habit of questioning becomes Nand's greatest weapon, for the day a crocodile comes that only a question can defeat.

● Questioning as defence

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Gaṅgeśa's four pramāṇas (–97, –38) taught to children in plain speech.
- Every new crocodile succeeds on those who do not ask.
- Nand's habit of questioning is explicitly the weapon for the climax to come.



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Chapter -20

The First Reckoning of the Plunge

छपाकक पहिल हिसाब *Chapākak Pahil Hisāb*

"The first plunge — the first name in the water — one who kept the account made the crocodile a witness."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Nand, on a bridge site, sees a vanished laborer with no account — and starts his diary

The bridge of the name

The First Reckoning of the Plunge • छुपाकक पहिल हिसाब — card 1 of 1

The vanished laborer. Nand, now an engineer carrying Āruṇi's tradition, works at a bridge site — but never forgot Ananyā's questioning. He sees the laborers' broken huts, low wages, lack of safety, and hears a tale that shakes him: a laborer who vanished one night, his name struck from the contractor's papers as if he had never existed.

The witness of his blood. Būṛhbā: "This reminds me of Sukhdev Mahto — laborers whose names appear in no official account. You are an engineer, but within you is also a witness, of my blood. Find that laborer's name, and hold it. A bridge joins two sides — but there is another bridge to build, between the name and the account, which the system breaks."

The diary begins. "A vanished laborer's body may not be found; but his name, if you hold it, will not be wholly lost. This is your real legacy — not the bridge of stone, but the bridge of the name." That night Nand writes his first diary line — "the crocodile eats the body, not the name." With that page, the diary he calls "the reckoning of the plunge" begins, and Nand becomes the village's next witness.

● *The witness takes up the pen*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The vanished laborer echoes Sukhdev (-92) — names outside the official account.
- The real legacy is the bridge of the name, not the bridge of stone.
- Nand's diary — the "reckoning of the plunge" — begins, tying to the title's jalsamādhi.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -19

Satyavrat's Decision

सत्यव्रतक निर्णय *Satyavratak Nirṇay*

"A decision that came late is the steadiest — Satyavrat stayed silent, but stood, at last, for the name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The years of quiet evidence form a pattern — and the moment to speak arrives

The evidence must speak

Satyavrat's Decision • सत्यव्रतक निर्णय — card 1 of 1

The pattern. Now a senior official, Satyavrat reopens his old notebook; the dates and accounts recorded quietly for years, placed together, show a terrifying pattern — as if scattered dots finally made a picture. Money passes account to account and finally to a distant overseas account; some names recur. It is no ordinary embezzlement, but a large, organized net whose threads spread far beyond the village.

The moment near. Būṛhbā: "You gathered evidence for years; now it is time for the evidence to speak. But be careful — the power you challenge can be merciless. Such power is defeated not by accusation but by proof. Don't fight alone — find those who can stand with you, an honest official, a witness. This fight of the name is the whole village's, not one man's."

No turning back. Returning, Satyavrat knows the net's threads perhaps reach the glass tower Abhinav once spoke of. But Būṛhbā's words — "silence that becomes injustice" — echo in his ears, and he understands there is no turning back. He keeps the notebook safe and waits for the right moment, knowing truth comes with solid proof, and that he is not alone.

● *Breaking the silence*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Patient evidence, gathered over years, finally reveals the pattern.
- Great power is defeated by proof, and with allies — not alone.
- The net's threads reach the glass tower (Lau Kin-hang, -32) — the strands converge.



The Meeting of Ananyā and Nand

अनन्या आ नन्दक भेंट *Ananyā ā Nandak Bheṇṭ*

"Two roads met in one place, a new journey began — those whose purpose is one walk in step."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The teacher and the engineer meet in a shared project — two paths, one journey

Question and construction, joined

The Meeting of Ananyā and Nand • अनन्या आनन्दक भेंट — card 1 of 1

The shared project. Nand returns and works with Ananyā to modernize the Nārikel-pāt Pāṭhaśālā — preserving the village's heritage digitally. The teacher who taught him to question and the engineer who sees name and account as a bridge come together for the first time. Ananyā knows every old tale, song, and panjī; Nand knows how to keep them permanently — their work completing each other, extending Gop Kumar's compilation.

One direction. Working together, they notice how their values match — both want to save names, hold truth, make the village's memory immortal. Two paths that began separately now flow in one direction. Būṛhbā, glad: "You are carrying Gop Kumar's work forward. The final chapter I've awaited is now near."

Two shoulders for the burden. "Some work isn't done alone. Being a witness is a burden, and two shoulders make it lighter. Question and construction, memory and technology, complete each other. The final chapter will be so hard that not one person, but two standing together, can bear it." The shared journey they begin will, ahead, bind not only the village's tale but their own lives to each other.

● The two witnesses converge

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Memory (Ananyā) and technology (Nand) join to carry the record forward.
- The witness-burden is lighter borne by two — the final chapter needs both.
- Their shared journey will bind the village's tale and their own lives together.



The Net of the Glass Tower

शीशाक मीनारक जाल *Śīsāk Mīnārak Jāl*

"The glass tower glitters from afar, a net within — one dazzled by the glitter is bound in the net."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Lau Kin-hang's scam-net, in its full extent, reaches near the village

The most terrible crocodile joins many at once

The Net of the Glass Tower • शीशाक मीनारक जाल — card 1 of 1

Three crocodiles, one net. News keeps coming of a vast Hong Kong-run digital net tied to Lau Kin-hang — no ordinary fraud, but job-scams, investment fraud, and human trafficking joined together, its threads across dozens of countries. It is built so no one sees its full form: a "good job" to one youth, "double your money" to one investor, captivity abroad to one poor person — each thread separate, all returning to one glass tower.

Already here. As Ananyā and Nand grasp its extent, a deep dread settles. Ananyā: "I fear it could reach Gaṛh Nārikel." Būṛhbā: "I fear it has already reached — as Ujjwal's dream, as Baṭuknāth's fall. It will one day touch a village name directly. I don't know which, but I feel it."

Awareness and the name. "I've seen many crocodiles — of water, of time, of the screen. But this net is most terrible, for it joins many at once: it eats the body, the money, and the name. My one weapon — awareness, and the name. If the village stays alert and holds its every name, this net can't take root within." Ananyā warns every youth anew, feeling the day is not far.

● The convergent threat

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The net unifies three crocodiles — job-scam, investment fraud, trafficking.
- It eats body, money, and name together — the most terrible yet.
- Awareness and the held name are the only defence against it.



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Chapter -16

Baṭuknāth's Final Turn

बटुकनाथक अंतिम मोड़ *Baṭuknāthak Antim Moṛ*

"A wrong road too asks for a turn at its end — Baṭuknāth, at the last, turned back toward his name."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Baṭuknāth gives his legal skill fully to the dark power's service

The witness holds the guilty name too, in truth

Baṭuknāth's Final Turn • बटुकनाथक अंतिम मोड़ — card 1 of 1

Justice's weapon turned. Baṭuknāth now works in the defence of big scam-cases — taking date after date, tiring witnesses, tangling evidence, delaying justice until the victim, exhausted, falls silent. Counted among the lawyers whom big offenders seek, he wins, grows rich, gains prestige — but behind each victory hides some poor person's defeat. The skill he learned for justice has become injustice's greatest weapon.

Held, yet a sorrow. Nand: "He has fully turned to darkness. I grieve." Būṛhbā, sadly: "I hold his name, hoping he'll change. But some names, even held, remain a source of sorrow. My work is not to change his decision, but to keep his tale in truth."

Neither curse nor erasure. "Being a witness is a hard dharma — it holds not only good names but guilty ones, in truth. I neither curse Baṭuknāth nor hide his fault; I keep his tale as it is. For if I erase his fall, the lesson from that truth is erased too." Nand records the whole journey without hatred or pardon — so someone may learn that no one is born guilty: system, temptation, and choice shape him together.

● The ethic of the witness

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The bright boy's fall completes — his skill now delay and defeat of the poor.
- A witness records the guilty name too, without curse or erasure.
- Truth, however painful, must be saved — the fall is itself the lesson.



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Chapter -15

Chandrapāl's Account

चन्द्रपालक खाता *Chandrapālak Khātā*

"An account not understood makes even a signature heavy — ignorance too is a knot in the net."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Chandrapāl, drowned in betting debt, becomes a "mule account" for the net

Each thread isolated, only Būṛhbā sees the whole

Chandrapāl's Account • चन्द्रपालक खाता — card 1 of 1

"Commission work." Chandrapāl, caught in heavy betting debt, lets the net use his bank account — money passing hand to hand through it. He doesn't fully understand: told it is only "commission work," he keeps a share, not grasping that in each transaction some poor person's swindled money flows. In the greed for debt-relief, he becomes a knot in the net.

The threads bind. Satyavrat sees every transaction of that account — a small but important thread of the vast net. The name in Ujjwal's dream, in Baṭuknāth's fall, now joins in Chandrapāl's account. Būṛhbā: "I held his name not knowing which way his tale would turn. Ujjwal, Baṭuknāth, Chandrapāl, and that glass-tower shadow — all are being woven into one net."

Only I see the thread. "The net is woven so each is unknown to the other — Ujjwal doesn't know Baṭuknāth, Baṭuknāth doesn't know Chandrapāl. But I, from afar, see all these names bound in one thread. When they come to one place, that final chapter completes — the village's hardest." Satyavrat gathers his evidence more carefully, waiting for silence to become testimony.

● The knot of ignorance

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- A mule account: ignorance is no shield — it is itself a knot in the net.
- The net keeps each participant isolated and unknowing.
- Only the witness, from afar, sees the whole thread binding the names.



The Building of the Bridge

पुलक निर्माण *Pulak Nirmāṇ*

"A bridge joins two sides, but does not forget the water — one who built it kept the flood in mind."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Nand is posted at a new bridge site — where the coming story's seed is sown

Build the bridge, but keep the watch

The Building of the Bridge • पुलक निर्माण — card 1 of 1

The village joined to the world. Nand is posted at a new bridge over the Kamalā-Balān that will connect the village directly to the city. But his questioning eye sees the laborers' lack of safety, work at heights without helmets, a contractor treating laborers as numbers, not names — and he recalls the laborer who vanished from a bridge, his account unkept. Unfamiliar brokers and unclear faces come and go from the city.

The same road brings the crocodile. Būṛhbā: "What you see reminds me of Sukhdev again — the laborers' names and safety are your responsibility, not only the bridge's strength. A bridge connects — good — but the route that brings the world to the village can bring that new crocodile too. Build the bridge, but keep the watch."

The name that builds. "Hold the name of every laborer who builds it with his sweat — the name that builds should be first in the account." Nand writes each name in his diary, asks their condition, fights the contractor for their safety — not knowing this very bridge, this very site, would become the stage of the final chapter whose footfall Būṛhbā has heard so long.

● The stage is set

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The bridge to the world is also the road the new crocodile can take.
- The witness-ethic applied to labour: hold every builder's name and safety.
- This site, unknown to Nand, is the coming climax's stage.



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Chapter -13

Gop Kumar's Compilation

गोप कुमारक संकलन *Gop Kumārak Saṅkalan*

"One who joined name to name made a history — a compilation saves not the body, but the memory."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Gop Kumar nears giving his lifelong documentation a complete form

A lamp for the dark moment to come

Gop Kumar's Compilation · गोप कुमारक संकलन — card 1 of 1

The threads come together. Gop Kumar, now old, hand trembling and eyes weak, sits to place his lifelong compilation in one place — from Yādavānand's shadow-panjī and Haripati's book to the modern digital record. As he joins pages, all the threads come together: the śaṅkha-rajata illusion, Hulāsā's water-burial, Sukhdev's unnamed death, Baṭuknāth's fall, Ujjwal's dream, Chandrapāl's account — tales once separate now forming one picture.

The footsteps, now clear. Būṛhbā: "That final chapter is near, very near. Nand's bridge, Chandrapāl's account, Baṭuknāth's court, and that unseen glass tower — all are about to meet in one place, at one time. Your compilation completes at just the right time — the coming chapter's witness needs the whole prior tale ready in hand."

The empty space. Seeing his whole compilation at once, Gop Kumar realizes he has revived every person who ever made the village's tale — yet an empty space remains: the final chapter, awaited year by year. He works faster, knowing his lifework will be the foundation on which Nand stands to face the village's greatest test.

● The foundation laid

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The whole counter-history, from śaṅkha-rajata to today, joined into one picture.
- The compilation completes just as the final chapter approaches.
- It becomes the lamp and foundation for Nand's coming ordeal.



The Trembling of the Channā Grove

चन्ना गाछीक कँपकँपी *Channā Gāchīk Kāpkāpī*

"The grove trembled, the village heard — something is about to happen; when the grove speaks, the village understands."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Būṛhbā, one with the whole grove, feels the tremble of an imminent event

The witness-grove gives its warning

The Trembling of the Channā Grove • चन्ना गाछीक कँपकँपी — card 1 of 1

A still-air tremble. One evening, without clear cause, every tree of the Channā grove — from the pīpal to every channā tree — trembles faintly together, though the air is still. No wind, no leaf stirring; yet for a moment the whole grove, as if drawing a deep breath, trembles at once. The villagers, feeling it, gather afraid at the pīpal.

One with the grove. Nand and Ananyā run up. Būṛhbā, unsteady: "I don't know what it is, but some big event is near — my whole existence, from every root, feels it. After my water-burial, my memory settled in these trees, these roots. When the grove trembles, I myself tremble — and only when something is coming that can shake every name in the village. This tremble is a warning."

The omen recalled. The oldest woman, over ninety, recalls seeing this tremble once in childhood — after which came the great flood that washed away half the village. The village grows more alert: if the grove trembled so hard, the coming event will be as big. That night they gather at the grove, lamps burning, awaiting the unknown thing whose footfall the whole grove is giving.

● *The omen of the climax*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Būṛhbā and the grove are one — the tremble is his own foreboding.
- Such a tremble has preceded only the village's greatest turning-points.
- An omen (echoing the comet of -61) that the final chapter is imminent.



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Chapter -11

Būṛhbā's Last Blessing

बूढ़बाक अन्तिम आशीर्वाद *Būṛhbāk Antim Āśīrvād*

"A blessing gives not the body but the name — Būṛhbā's last words became the seed of the next generation."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Būṛhbā gives Nand a blessing and warning for the role that is coming

You will not be alone

Būṛhbā's Last Blessing · बूढ़बाक अन्तिम आशीर्वाद — card 1 of 1

The handing-over. The night after the grove trembled, Būṛhbā calls Nand alone to the pīpal, one lamp burning, his face graver than Nand has ever seen. "You are my descendant, Āruṇi's grandson, and I feel a great test is coming in your life." To Nand it feels not like a tale but a farewell — as if Būṛhbā were placing his centuries' burden on his shoulders.

The ancestors' courage. "When that time comes, listen to your heart. Within you is the courage of Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Gaurī, Sunaynā — all our ancestors. You won't be alone. I, and our whole tale, will be with you, whether you see me or not."

Remember the names. "When the dark moment comes, you'll think you're alone — but that's an illusion. Every name I've held will stand behind you. The courage of those who didn't fear the flood, didn't bow in famine, didn't stay silent before injustice, dwells in your every breath. When fear comes, remember your name, and all the names that brought you here." Nand's heart, without saying no, accepts the burden.

● The witness-role passes to Nand

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Būṛhbā hands his centuries' burden of witness to Nand.
- In the dark moment, the isolation will be an illusion — the held names stand behind.
- "You will not be alone" becomes Nand's support for the ordeal to come.



The First Plunge on the Bridge

पुलपर पहिल छपाक *Pulpar Pahil Chapāk*

"The first plunge on the bridge — the first name in the water — the one who drowned, his name too rose on the leaf."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- At the bridge site, the accident finally happens whose footfall was long heard

He must not die twice

The First Plunge on the Bridge • पुलपर पहिल छपाक — card 1 of 1

The plunge. One moonless night, the river at full force after rain, the tired laborers work in the dark without full light or safety. Suddenly a laborer — his name still unclear — falls into the river. The sound of "chapāk" (the plunge) reaches the nearest hamlet — that same sound echoing through the village's tale year by year. Nand jumps in, but in the dark and current cannot save him; he reaches for the hand, calls the name — and gets neither.

Not your fault. Nand returns weeping, river-water and tears become one. Būṛhbā, gently: "This is the moment whose footfall I heard year by year. It is not your fault, but the fault of that darkness, that current, and a system that sees a laborer as a number, not a name. You couldn't save his body; but his name you can save."

The reckoning of the plunge. "If no one holds his name, that man dies twice — once in the water, once in the village's memory." Nand gives his life to finding that name and others like it — the search becoming the diary "the reckoning of the plunge," written every night, on whose first page he again writes: "the crocodile eats the body, not the name."

● The title-event arrives

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The jalsamādhi / "chapāk" of the title occurs — a nameless laborer drowns.
- The system that counts numbers, not names, is the true culprit.
- Nand's diary "छपाकक हिसाब" is formalized — to save names from a second death.



The Beginning of the Investigation

जाँचक आरम्भ *Jācak Ārambha*

"Investigation is like digging a well — first the mud, then the water; one who begins to dig will reach the truth."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- After the death, Nand and Satyavrat meet — the name-thread and the money-thread

Two threads of one net

The Beginning of the Investigation • जाँचक आरम्भ — card 1 of 1

The fake name. Nand digs for the laborer's name — the contractor's papers, the attendance-register, the man's companions. But the deeper he digs, the darker it grows: the laborer worked under a fake name and fake age; no one knew the real one, as if the man had lost his name while alive. The company's papers are unclear, its money moving somewhere far by hidden routes — a thread of a large, unseen net.

Name and money. Satyavrat, watching the company's banking, meets Nand: "I have investigated this company's suspicious transactions for years. You seek the laborers' names, I the money's route — perhaps our searches will meet." Būṛhbā: "Work together. One thread — the name — in your hand; the other — the money — in Satyavrat's. When both come together, the net will show its full form."

The net's two ends. From that day they investigate together — Nand by the name, Satyavrat by the money — matching evidence, and as they join the threads the vast net's form slowly clears: the drowned laborer of Gaṛh Nārikel on one side, and far away, the unseen glass tower on the other. "A net this vast has a hand behind it as powerful and merciless."

● The investigators unite

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Nand's name-thread and Satyavrat's money-thread are one net.
- The village's drowned laborer connects directly to Lau Kin-hang's tower.
- Patience in the digging — first the mud, then the clear water of truth.



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Chapter -8

The Evidence Comes to Light

प्रमाणक बाहर आएब *Pramāṇak Bāhar Āeb*

"Evidence hidden in the dark will one day see the dawn — truth stays at the water's bed, but surely rises."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Satyavrat's years-old evidence finally reaches the court and the media

Truth is a lamp, not a sun

The Evidence Comes to Light • प्रमाणक बाहर आएब — card 1 of 1

The notebook speaks. Satyavrat, with Gop Kumar's help, gets his notebook's whole evidence to a trustworthy journalist and an honest agency. The dates, accounts, and transactions once locked in one silent man's notebook now come to light — and the net's form clears: Ujjwal's debt, Baṭuknāth's legal aid, Chandrapāl's mule account, and Lau Kin-hang's Hong Kong operation form one terrifying picture.

A lamp, not a sun. Nand fears the truth is too vast to be fully found. Būṛhbā: "The whole truth never comes at once. Truth is not a sun but a lamp — it doesn't erase all darkness, it gives only enough light to see the next step. Those who wait for the whole truth never speak; those who bring out their piece weaken the darkness, one lamp at a time."

Grief with a name. When the net's tale is first printed, villagers see names once whispered in courtyards now on the newspaper page. Some families who lost sons understand, for the first time, that their grief had a name and a cause — and in that knowledge, along with grief, a faint peace. A lamp once lit cannot easily be put out; darkness, for the first time, begins to retreat.

● *The reckoning made public*

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The silent notebook's evidence reaches court and media; the net is exposed.
- Truth is a lamp — each piece weakens the dark, not a single blaze.
- Naming the loss gives the grieving families a fragile peace.



The Experience of the Half-Ghost

आधा-भूतक अनुभव *Ādhā-Bhūtak Anubhav*

"Half-truth and half-ghost — both frighten; one who knows the full name fears no half-ghost."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Amid the investigation and grief, Nand first senses Būṛhbā with his own eyes

One foot in the present, one among the names

The Experience of the Half-Ghost • आधा-भूतक अनुभव — card 1 of 1

The tender gaze. One night, tired and grieving, Nand sleeps by the pīpal's root, head on the witness-tree, and descends where the line between dream and truth grows thin. In the dream he sees Būṛhbā somewhat clearly — an old figure between smoke and light, his eyes holding a tenderness that gives Nand peace. Būṛhbā says nothing, only looks, as if saying: "you are on the right path."

The half-ghost. His grandmother smiles at the dream: "You've become a half-ghost. One who prepares to be a witness becomes somewhat like that. Būṛhbā is no ghost to frighten — he is the memory that has saved the village. One who holds names dwells in both worlds — one foot in the present, one among all the names that have passed. You stand on that threshold."

The voice that separates. Nand asks her the old tales — the śaṅkha-rajata, Hulāsā's water-burial, Sukhdev's nameless death — and feels them becoming his own, as if Būṛhbā's twelve hundred years and his few years slowly dissolve together. From that day he hears Būṛhbā's voice clearer — in the wind, the leaves, the inner voice that separates right from wrong; real or imagined, it keeps him on the path.

● Crossing the threshold

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Nand becomes a "half-ghost" — the witness-liminality (echoing Būṛhbā, -89).
- Holding names means dwelling in two worlds — present and remembered.
- Būṛhbā's tale and Nand's life begin to merge into one.



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Chapter -6

Gop Kumar's Last Page

गोप कुमारक अन्तिम पन्ना *Gop Kumārak Antim Pannā*

"The last page in whose hand, he bears the tale's burden — Gop Kumar, handing over the name, grew light."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Gop Kumar completes his lifelong compilation and hands it to Nand and Ananyā

The witness changes, the tale does not break

Gop Kumar's Last Page • गोप कुमारक अन्तिम पन्ना — card 1 of 1

The last name. Gop Kumar, very old, completes the last page of his lifelong compilation — Būṛhbā's whole tale from Vācaspati Miśra to today. When he writes the last name, a peace comes to his face that only one who has fulfilled his life's purpose finds. Centuries of memory — śaṅkha-rajata, Hulāsā's water-burial, Sukhdev's nameless death, Yādavānand's panjī, Gaṅgādhār's press, the digital record — woven in one thread: the village's soul, preserved.

Into the next hands. He hands it to Nand and Ananyā: "This is my lifework. Now it is yours. Būṛhbā said the final chapter still remains — perhaps you will write it." Būṛhbā: "In every generation one tends memory. Yādavānand was such, Vibhā was such, you are such. What your hand joined is hundreds of lives' tale. Now the burden passes — but your name, in every page, will live forever."

The grove's farewell. What Nand and Ananyā receive from his trembling hand is not paper but a vow to fulfill with their lives. Some months later Gop Kumar passes peacefully — his compilation safe in their hands. That night, it is said, a faint rustle rose from every root of the grove, as if Būṛhbā and all the names bade a respectful farewell to one old, tired, but complete witness.

● The torch passes

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The whole counter-history is completed and handed to Nand and Ananyā.
- The witness changes each generation; the tale itself does not break.
- Gop Kumar dies fulfilled — the grove's rustle is the ancestors' farewell.



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Chapter -5

The Net Exposed

जालक उजागर होएब *Jālak Ujāgar Hoeb*

"When the net was uncovered, not the fish but the fisher was caught — one who saw the net recognized the crocodile."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Nand and Satyavrat's evidence exposes the net — at least locally

An incomplete victory is still a step

The Net Exposed • जालक उजागर होएब — card 1 of 1

Into the light. Months of investigation bring the net's local form to light: Baṭuknāth's participation and Chandrapāl's mule account both stand exposed. Baṭuknāth — the reputed lawyer — must for the first time stand in the dock; Chandrapāl faces hard investigation, for one caught in the net, even unknowingly, bears his share before the law. But one name stays beyond reach: the shadow in the glass tower, Lau Kin-hang.

The seed of the next fight. Nand: "Our victory is incomplete." Būṛhbā: "In chapter -84, Yaśpati's end too was incomplete. Some darkness is never fully uncovered, only weakened — this too is progress. Every incomplete victory leaves a seed for the next generation. Lau Kin-hang may escape today, but the evidence you leave, someone will one day take up."

The net trembles. When Baṭuknāth stands in the dock, the elders who knew him as a boy watch — with less satisfaction of justice than grief for a lost dream. Nand sees the incomplete victory not as defeat but as a step, keeping every proof safe for the day someone brings the surviving shadow into the light too. The net did not fully break — but for the first time, it trembled.

● Partial justice

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The local net is exposed; the trans-national head (Lau Kin-hang) still escapes.
- Some darkness is only weakened, not erased — and that is still progress.
- Every incomplete victory leaves a seed and a proof for the next generation.



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Chapter -4

The Final List of Names

नामक अन्तिम सूची *Nāmak Antim Sūcī*

"The name that was left out was joined at the last — the list complete, the crocodile's reckoning was done."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Nand completes, in his diary, the real names of every bridge-accident victim

Numbers made names again

The Final List of Names • नामक अन्तिम सूची — card 1 of 1

The search. After months, Nand recovers the real name of every laborer who died at the bridge site — going village to village, family to family, matching the contractor's struck-out papers with the laborers' forgotten addresses, until each man the system had made a mere number became a name again.

Thirty names. Thirty names, tied to a toll the official account had forgotten. Nand records all thirty in his "reckoning of the plunge" diary — beside each, the village, the family, the story. Those lost in three places at once — in water, in paper, and in memory — now live again, at least in one: the diary. Būṛhbā: "You are my most worthy descendant; your diary will become the next chapter of my whole tale."

A mother's tears. Among the thirty is a youth whose mother had watched the road every evening for years. When Nand shows her the son's name recorded in his diary, she weeps for the first time in long — for now, at least, she knows his name will never be lost. Nand feels himself a link in the long chain from śaṅkha-rajata to now, carrying Būṛhbā's twelve-hundred-year vow into his own generation.

● Restoring the erased

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The diary recovers the real names the system reduced to numbers.
- A name held is a body that no longer dies a second death.
- Nand carries the twelve-hundred-year vow into his own generation.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT

Chapter -3

The Completion of Twelve Hundred Years

बारह सय बरखक पूर्णता *Bārah Say Barakhak Pūrṇatā*

"The circle of twelve hundred years was completed — a new-moon night; what began, stood again at the end."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- On a new-moon night, the whole village calls the names — the circle closes

The burden shared by a thousand breaths

The Completion of Twelve Hundred Years • बारह सय बरखक पूर्णता — card 1 of 1

Nand joins the play. On a new-moon night the whole village gathers at the Channā grove for kabaddī — the old tradition where a player, in one breath, calls the ancestors' names, so the lost live again in the game's breath. This time Nand, so long only a witness, joins the play; when his turn comes the village falls silent, knowing Būṛhbā's next witness is raising his voice for the first time.

Collective remembrance. Nand runs, calling: "Hulāsā! Sukhdev! Ratnā! Gaṅgeśa! Gaurī! Sāvitri!" — and the elders join, adding their own ancestors, a lost brother who went abroad and never returned. The kabaddī turns into a collective remembrance, the whole village in one voice reviving every name of centuries in the dark.

The vow becomes the village's. Būṛhbā, from every root of the grove: "Twelve hundred years, Nand — and today, for the first time, the burden feels not mine alone but yours, all of you. The vow that wearied one breath is now shared by a thousand — this is my greatest reward." The grove trembles with the names, and for the first time in twelve hundred years, Būṛhbā feels a little lighter.

● The circle closes

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The kabaddī of names (from -82) becomes a whole-village collective remembrance.
- The witness-burden passes from one breath to a thousand.
- Beginning and end stand together — Būṛhbā's twelve-hundred-year vow is fulfilled.



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Chapter -2

The Vow of the Next Generation

अगिला पीढ़ीक वचन *Agilā Pīrhīk Vacan*

"The vow the next generation takes saves the village — holding the name is not rescue; hearing it is release."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- Nand, Ananyā, and the youth vow to carry the witness-tradition forward

Every skill joined in one vow

The Vow of the Next Generation • अगिला पीढ़ीक वचन — card 1 of 1

A new pledge. After the kabaddī, as the new-moon dark thins, Nand and Ananyā gather the youth and take a new pledge at the pīpal, the just-called names still echoing. The new generation stands to lift their ancestors' vow onto their own shoulders — the children who learned to question in Ananyā's school, the youth who joined records with Nand, all in one voice.

Coconut-leaf to digital. Nand: "We vow to carry forward Būṛhbā's tale, Gop Kumar's compilation, and every name." Ananyā: "We will use every tool, from the coconut-leaf school to the digital archive, so this tale is never lost." Būṛhbā accepts the vow with a calm, steady light, as if the tale were now in safe hands.

No one alone. Some of the youth know code, some folk-song and panjī, some law and accounts — and that night they join their skills in one vow. The inheritance Būṛhbā began with śaṅkha-rajata now passes, twelve hundred years on, into a whole generation's hands. In that light the village feels Būṛhbā say: "I am not alone — and now, you are not alone either."

● The inheritance passes on

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- The witness-burden becomes a whole generation's, not one person's.
- Code, song, panjī, and law joined in a single shared vow.
- Nand and Ananyā move toward the final chapter, now very near.



VOL-0 • PRE-HISTORY • NOVEL EXCERPT • VOL-0 FINALE

Chapter -1

The Final Witness

अन्तिम साक्षी *Antim Sākṣī*

"The final witness who spoke turned the tale to another hand — the crocodile eats the body, not the name: the village's last refrain."

● This chapter

SOURCE

- The last chapter of Vol-0 — Būṛhbā tells Nand the final secret of his tale

The tale folds into its own telling

The Final Witness · अन्तिम साक्षी — card 1 of 1

The secret. One last evening, Būṛhbā calls Nand alone to the pīpal: "I want to tell you something I've felt for years but never fully understood — I feel that my tale, in some form, far ahead, someone will write. Some writer I will never see, who will put my every name, every tear, every hope, onto paper."

Near enough to speak. Nand, stunned: "How do you know this?" Būṛhbā, smiling for the last time: "I don't know, Nand. I only feel it. And now I feel that writer is very near — perhaps near enough that I am speaking with you, in this very moment."

The curtain's edge. Nand stayed silent. That night, in the pīpal's shade, Būṛhbā's voice seemed to come from beyond the stage — and at that moment, from the far side of the stage, the sūtradhāra stepped out one last time from beside the curtain, stood before the reader, and spoke. So Vol-0 ends by folding into the act of its own telling, opening onto the नाट्य (theatre) that follows.

● The metafictional close of Vol-0

TEACHING TAKEAWAY

- Būṛhbā foresees the author (a mirror of Gajendra himself) who will write his tale.
- The fourth wall breaks: the sūtradhāra steps out to address the reader.
- Vol-0's refrain — "the crocodile eats the body, not the name" — becomes its last word.